NO. 155 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SATURDAY 7 NOVEMBER 2026 · THE WEEKEND EDITION



ONE OF TWO KNOWN, AND THE ESTIMATE IS THE RISK (P10)

THE GOOD LIFE

Phillips offers one of two known steel Patek 1436s in Geneva today, at two to four million francs

THE TRAVEL DESK

Angkor's foreign visitors are down 26 per cent, and November is the one month with full moats

THE RABBIT HOLE

Origami's grail sheet costs twenty euros, and the hobby's core problem is provably intractable

Source: Phillips — lot 95, The Geneva Watch Auction: XXIV, photographed for the catalogue. Steel reference 1436, 1945.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 155

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THE UNPINNED NUMBER. Every figure in this issue counts something other than the thing it is named after. A majority that is thirteen short (p3). A yield that fell for the opposite reason (p14). A hat grade with no standard (p6). An occlusion pressure measured in an unrecorded posture (p18). And a quarter of a medicine, carved out by ministerial order (p25).

FROM THE DESK

"Attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity."

Simone Weil, letter to the poet Joë Bousquet, 13 April 1942[1]

Which is the whole of the Scoreboard below, and of p18, where an entire literature prescribed a percentage of a pressure nobody looked at closely enough to record.

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[2]	4.86%	▼ 8bp wk
US 10-year real[2]	2.63%	▲ 3bp wk
VWRA	$184.98	▼ 1.89%
BNDW	$67.06	▲ 0.28%
Gold[3]	$4,074.60	▲ 4.51%
Bitcoin[3]	$75,800	▼ 1.81%
Brent	$97.93	▼ 16.8%
USD/SGD	1.2831	▲ 0.27%
Straits Times	5,179.17	▼ 3.67%

The Straits Times fell further than the index that contains Nvidia (p14). Gold is a futures settle and bitcoin a snapshot. Not advice.[3]

THE SCOREBOARD · SATURDAY

Forty-five calls came due: 29 right, 9 wrong, 2 pushes, 5 we could not settle. Misses first, and one caveat that matters: five of the twenty-nine are the same Japanese tax-free call bought five times across different issues. On distinct propositions the record is 24–9–2–5.[4]

We said the Federal Reserve would raise in October. It held at 3.75 to 4.00 per cent on the 28th, 10 votes to 2. The only people who wanted our hike were the two dissenters.

Half a regime call is a wrong one. No. 127 said the term premium would stay above 0.90 through October and the ten-year real yield above 2.70. The term premium obliged, bottoming at 0.9089. The real yield broke on 22 October and finished the month at 2.60.

We said nothing would be published from the Xi state visit. A fact sheet went up on the White House site on 25 September — the day after — carrying precursor controls, American coal commitments and a US–China "Super Intelligence Dialogue".

The hits worth naming. Japan's tax-free switch landed on 1 November exactly as called, five times over (p19); Mistral published the Large 4 weights on 29 October, three days inside the deadline; Samsung's mobile division lost 0.6 trillion won, not 19; Singapore's air quality cleared all five regions on 28 October, worst reading 79; and *Klara and the Sun* fell 77.5 per cent in its second weekend, against the 60 we predicted.

SOURCES 1 Simone Weil to Joë Bousquet, 13 April 1942; «L'attention est la forme la plus rare et la plus pure de la générosité», published in their *Correspondance* (Lausanne: L'Âge d'Homme, 1982), p. 18. 2 The United States Treasury's own daily par and real yield-curve files for 2026, read at source on 7 November; the weekly changes are measured against 30 October and are this desk's arithmetic on those two published series (p14). 3 Levels at Friday 6 November's close, each sourced instrument by instrument on p14. **Gold is a December futures settle, not a London fix, because the bullion association has moved its tables behind a licence wall; bitcoin trades continuously and its close is a snapshot; the Singapore index is single-sourced because the exchange refused this desk.** 4 Every claim in this magazine's own predictions ledger whose check-by date had passed was graded against a figure read where it is published: a central bank's own statement; the Treasury's own curve files; the New York Federal Reserve's term-premium series; a national tourism body's own guidance; a model repository's commit history; a chipmaker's own results deck; a national environment agency's own air-quality interface; an exchange's own reserves page; a maker's own store listing; and a box-office tracker's weekend page. **Five claims could not be settled and are recorded as unresolved rather than graded.**

THE WORLD · ISRAEL & THE MANDATE

Herzog names a prime minister on Sunday after 67 members back Gadi Eisenkot

Netanyahu got 46. But 19 of the 67 are Arab-led members both men refuse to govern with, which leaves Eisenkot on 48 of 120 — thirteen short.

Israel's president, Isaac Herzog, said on Thursday 5 November that he will name a candidate to form a government on Sunday 8 November, after 67 of the Knesset's 120 members recommended Gadi Eisenkot and 46 recommended Benjamin Netanyahu.[1]

Israel votes for parties, not for a prime minister. After an election the president asks every party whom it wants, then hands one person a mandate: 28 days to assemble a majority of 61, extendable by 14. If that fails the mandate moves on, and if nobody succeeds the country votes again. This is the first time since 2022 that the count has gone against Netanyahu, who has been caretaker prime minister since the ballot on 27 October.[1]

The party that broke it was not on the other side. **United Torah Judaism**, seven seats and a Netanyahu partner for four years, recommended nobody at all, over his failure to pass the exemption that keeps yeshiva students out of the army. Likud remains the largest single party on 27 seats; Netanyahu's religious-nationalist bloc holds 53. Eisenkot's four-party Jewish-led alliance holds 48, and the two Arab-led parties a record 19.[2]

Herzog refused to treat 67 as decisive. The result, he said, "may appear clear", but there are "mutual vetoes between the blocs and within the blocs themselves". He is not obliged to pick the man with the most recommendations. On Friday **Avigdor Lieberman** dropped his veto on conscripting the ultra-Orthodox — the one obstacle to the religious parties' 13 seats crossing over, which is precisely the bridge from 48 to 61. The new Knesset is sworn in on 10 November.[3]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Reads the week backwards from Washington: the American midterms, not the Knesset count, are what made Netanyahu unsellable — and no new face repairs it. **Dov Waxman**, University of California: "the era of bipartisan support for Israel has ended."[4]

BEIJING — XINHUA

Treats it as a construction problem, not an obituary, and writes the Arab parties out of the sum from the first line: Shas and United Torah Judaism hold 13 seats, exactly the gap from 48 to 61. Lieberman's climb-down is the operative event.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT ISRAEL'S POLITICIANS SAID ABOUT EISENKOT'S 67

Yariv Oppenheimer of the Democrats, inside Eisenkot's alliance, told Al Jazeera he saw "no reason" Herzog would not pick him, and that United Torah Judaism's support was available "for the right price". **Ahmad Tibi** of the Joint List told the Associated Press his bloc would do things it had not done before to remove what he called a "criminal government". Lieberman asked for "painful compromises".[1]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY EISENKOT'S 67 IS REALLY 48

Nineteen of the 67 cannot be used. Both Eisenkot and Netanyahu have ruled out a government resting on the Arab-led parties, and three of the four Jewish-led parties in his own bloc refuse the partnership. Strip them out and he is thirteen short. **Miri Regev** of Likud argues the mandate belongs to the largest single party in any case — Likud, on 27. Netanyahu is meanwhile contesting the count itself. **What would settle it:** a signed coalition agreement with Shas or United Torah Judaism inside 28 days.[2]

7

SEATS HELD BY UNITED TORAH JUDAISM, WHICH RECOMMENDED NOBODY — THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN 53 AND A MAJORITY[2]

SOURCES 1 Al Jazeera, 6 November 2026, read at source, for the Sunday announcement, the 67–46 tally, Herzog's own words and the Oppenheimer and Tibi quotations. **The president's own site returned HTTP 307 to this desk and the Central Elections Committee's results server an empty body, so Herzog is quoted through the fullest direct report of his statement rather than from his own text.** 2 *The Times of Israel*, 5 November 2026, read at source, for the seat table, the conscription break, the Regev exchange and the mandate clock; *JNS*, 6 November, for the formal delivery of the certified results to the president on 4 November. 3 Xinhua, Jerusalem dateline, 6 November 2026, read at source, for Lieberman's abandoned veto and the 13-seat bridge. 4 Al Jazeera, 5 November 2026, read at source, for the Washington framing and the Waxman, Telhami and Bregman quotations.

THE WORLD · THE MECCA PACT

Turkey's parliament ratifies the Mecca defence pact, 279 to 119, on an unpublished text

Of Ankara's 592 sitting members, 398 voted, in an overnight session on 5 November. Syria's foreign minister says talks on joining are already under way.

The Turkish parliament ratified the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement with Saudi Arabia and Pakistan in an overnight session on Thursday 5 November, by 279 votes to 119. Of 592 sitting members, 398 cast a ballot. It was signed in Mecca on 7 August by Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, Mohammed bin Salman and Shehbaz Sharif.[1]

A mutual-defence pact is the promise at the centre of an alliance: an attack on one member is treated as an attack on all. This one binds the second-largest army in the Atlantic alliance to the only Muslim state with nuclear weapons and to the world's largest oil exporter. The awkwardness is that almost none of it can be checked: the full text has never been published, and every account of the clause rests on reporting.[2]

What is documented is the architecture: a reported 16 articles, a ministerial committee and a permanent secretariat in Saudi Arabia. It takes effect only when the last ratification is deposited there. Ratifying is not deploying: that needs a separate parliamentary mandate.[3]

The door is being used. Syria's foreign minister, **Asaad al-Shaibani**, says talks on Syrian entry are under way, and on 4 November the Saudi and Syrian defence ministries signed a cooperation agreement in Riyadh. This desk read the *Resmî Gazete* of 7 November: appointments, five regulation amendments, an energy decision, and no statute. The ratification law was not yet promulgated on Saturday morning.[1]

THE CHATTER · HOW ANKARA IS SELLING THE MECCA PACT

Ziya Altunyaldız, a governing-party member of the Turkish parliament, told *The New Arab* the pact "was not directed against any third country". **Saira Bano** of Thompson Rivers University, writing for the Lowy Institute, called it "strategic insurance whose deterrent value currently rests on uncertainty".[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE MECCA PACT MAY STAY ON PAPER

Yoel Guzansky and Gallia Lindenstrauss of Israel's Institute for National Security Studies call its viability "questionable": the text is unpublished; Pakistan refused the Saudi-led coalition in Yemen in 2015 and made no military answer to the 2019 attacks on Saudi oil facilities; and its warheads "do not provide an automatic nuclear umbrella", being aimed at India. Bano notes the public terms set out no command arrangements and no answer on attacks by non-state actors. **What would settle it:** a deployment mandate, or joint missile-defence planning.[2]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Paraguay impeached a president who had already quit. The Chamber of Deputies approved the accusation against **Santiago Peña** on 5 November by 78 votes to nought, over his stake in Ueno Holding and the state pension money concentrated in Ueno Bank, seized two days earlier. He resigned while the session sat. More than 60 per cent of Paraguayan adults banked there.[4]

The Bundibugyo outbreak in DR Congo has passed ten thousand confirmed cases — 10,532, with 5,126 deaths and a fatality rate of 48.7 per cent, to 1 November. That week alone added 480. The World Health Organization added two candidate vaccines to the trial on 4 November.[5]

398

OF 592 SITTING MEMBERS, THE NUMBER WHO VOTED ON A TREATY BINDING THREE STATES TO EACH OTHER'S DEFENCE[1]

SOURCES 1 Anadolu Agency morning briefing, 6 November 2026, read at source, for the 279–119 vote and the 398-of-592 turnout; the *Resmî Gazete* of 7 November 2026, issue 33423, read at source, for the absence of any statute. **The parliament's own record returned HTTP 308 and then 503, so no transcript was obtained and the party-by-party breakdown is not printed.** 2 Guzansky and Lindenstrauss, *INSS Insight* No. 2187, 20 August 2026, read at source; Saira Bano in *The Conversation*, 16 August 2026, read at source. 3 The Lowy Institute's *Interpreter*, 10 August 2026, read at source, for the sixteen articles and the secretariat; *The New Arab*, 6 November 2026, for Altunyaldız; the *Jerusalem Post* carrying Reuters, 6 November, for the Syrian talks and the Riyadh signing. **A sharper line about Iran sits adjacent to the Syrian minister's name on that page and could not be attributed with confidence, so it is omitted.** 4 The Paraguayan Chamber of Deputies' own bulletins of 4 and 5 November 2026, read at source; the Associated Press, 5 November, for the seizure and the deposit figures. 5 World Health Organization AFRO weekly external situation report 24, data to 1 November 2026, read at source; the WHO news release of 4 November 2026.

SINGAPORE · THE PRINCE GROUP MONEY

Police arrest Karen Chen at Changi over Prince Group; S$700m now restrained

Chen Xiuling, 44, was charged on Friday over a false agreement filed with JTC Corporation in September 2022 — a paperwork charge carrying ten years.

Singapore police arrested Chen Xiuling, a 44-year-old Singaporean also known as Karen Chen, at Changi Airport on Thursday 5 November, and charged her in court the following day. The force says she directed two companies it believes were beneficially owned by Chen Zhi, founder of Prince Holding Group.[1]

Prince Holding Group is the Cambodian conglomerate at the centre of the region's largest scam-compound investigation; its founder was sanctioned by Washington and London last year and sent to China this year. "Restrained" is the word that matters: an owner may not sell or move the asset while a case runs. The total frozen or seized in Singapore over the group has passed S$700 million.[1]

The charges are narrow — instigating another person to falsify accounts, and attempted cheating. Police say that in September 2022 Skyline Investment Management filed a business plan and a false agreement with **JTC Corporation**, the state industrial landlord, to take over a property lease, and that Chen instigated an officer of a second company to falsify it.[1]

The asset numbers are the larger story. Since June, police have issued prohibition-of-disposal orders over 14 properties and seized accounts worth about S$100 million in that tranche alone; an earlier tranche in October 2025 ran past S$150 million. In court the prosecution sought six days' remand. Chen asked to rest at home. The judge remanded her.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT SINGAPORE ASKED ABOUT KAREN CHEN'S ARREST

On HardwareZone's Current Affairs board the thread opened within an hour, and almost nobody argued about the money. They argued about the airport. **DulanMax**: "She still fly back to Changi??" **Joe Mahmood**: "Wonder why she returns to SG?"[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT CHEN IS ACTUALLY CHARGED WITH

The S$700 million and the charge sheet are doing different work, and the release does not join them. What Chen faces is a falsified lease document filed with an industrial landlord in 2022 — not laundering, not organised crime, not the scam proceeds. The statement names no official, carries no quotation, and does not say why a woman linked to a sanctioned group flew into Changi at all. **What would settle it:** a charge that attaches to the restrained assets rather than to a warehouse lease.[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Is Monday a holiday? Only if Sunday is your rest day. Deepavali falls tomorrow, and the Ministry of Manpower's own page lists it as one holiday, Sunday 8 November. Monday appears only as a condition: "Monday, 9 November 2026, will be a public holiday if your rest day falls on 8 November 2026." Where Sunday is merely a non-working day — most five-day office staff — the employer chooses between a day's pay and another day off. Three of this year's ten holidays are phrased that way.[4]

M1 and Doctor Anywhere both disclosed breaches on Friday night. M1 found its on 30 October, the telemedicine provider its on 29 October. Between them the exposed fields run to names, identity-card numbers, dates of birth, addresses and, at Doctor Anywhere, bank account details. Neither has said how many customers are affected. For scale, the privacy commission fined Courts S$178,000 last month over a 2022 attack touching almost a million people.[5]

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SINGAPORE HOLIDAYS THIS YEAR WHOSE MONDAY DEPENDS ON AN EMPLOYMENT CONTRACT RATHER THAN THE CALENDAR[4]

SOURCES 1 Singapore Police Force media release, 5 November 2026, read at source: the arrest, the two charges and their statutory maxima, the two companies, the 14 prohibition-of-disposal orders, the S$100 million tranche and the S$700 million total. 2 Mothership, 6 November 2026, read at source, for the remand application and the October 2025 tranche. 3 HardwareZone Current Affairs Lounge, thread opened 22:17 on 5 November 2026, read at source; handles as displayed. **Reddit refused this desk, so r/singapore is unread and nothing is attributed to it.** 4 The Ministry of Manpower's own public-holidays page, last updated 19 June 2026, and its rest-day FAQ, both read at source; the conditional sentence is quoted verbatim. **Singapore Statutes Online returned HTTP 403, so the Holidays Act schedule — the gazette position, as distinct from the employee entitlement — is unread, and this desk prints the ministry's own wording rather than a flat answer.** 5 MustShareNews, 7 November 2026, for both disclosures and the privacy commission's Courts decision of 26 October. **M1's own newsroom returned 404 and the telemedicine provider's incident page likewise, so neither company statement was read at source and no customer count is printed.**

THE ATELIER · STRAW & FELT HATS

The X rating on a Stetson has no standard, and Hatco says so itself

Stetson's own store prices a 1000X at $5,600 and a 10X at $600 and states beaver content for neither. Lock sells a Superfino Montecristi at £1,895.

A Panama hat is neither straw nor Panamanian, and the grade stamped inside it is not a measurement — so this page is about the two things in hats that can actually be counted. They are weaves per inch in woven straw, and what is physically in the felt.[1]

Start with the plant, because the vocabulary is wrong from the first word. A Panama is woven from split, boiled leaf fibre of *Carludovica palmata*, the toquilla, which is neither palm nor straw; it is woven in Ecuador and named for the port it shipped through. An object named for a harbour never carried its weaver's name, which is why a wholesaler's label goes inside instead.[1]

What separates the tiers is weave density, counted in weaves per square inch. **Brent Black**, the best-known Montecristi dealer in the world, says a numeric grade should be ignored outright: internally consistent within one seller, meaningless across sellers, with three named Ecuadorian exporters contradicting one another. His thresholds: under about 300 weaves not worth owning, over 900 exceptional. His fraud datum: hats badged "Super Fino Montecristi" selling under $20.[2]

Then felt, where the industry's own number is openly fictional. Posting as **Hatco** — which has made Stetson since 1987, in Garland, Texas since 2004 — a representative wrote: "Like it or not, public consensus is that we are the barometer for X's. We are the mean." And: "They may market them as a 8X or 10X hat but at a 4X price." Hats with no X were rejected by retailers.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT COLLECTORS SAY ABOUT STETSON'S X AND PANAMA GRADES

On the Fedora Lounge, **Matt Deckard** on Stetson's X: "The X never really meant anything… there was never a standard", and the measuring stick "is made of elastic". **barrowjh**: "Trying to determine 'quality' of the finished hat from just a list of critters' fur that was used in the felt is delusional." **Daniele Tanto**, the forum's historian of Italian hatters: "super Panamas… they are most an illusion".[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT A MONTECRISTI RESELLS FOR

The resale number is the case against the grail tier. In June 2025 a Fedora Lounge member wrote: "I gave Brent a $2,000 budget for this hat; with custom blocking and shipping, the final total came to $2,275." He listed it at "$700 shipped", cut it to $625, and sold — 30 per cent of cost, among people who know exactly what it is. **What would settle it:** any maker publishing a counted weave figure. **In Singapore** there is one serious Panama retailer, Hat of Cain at 43 Keong Saik Road, whose grade-12 'Anthony' is $615 with a 7cm brim — and no felt blocker or renovation workshop this desk could verify. Ask for a *calado* ventilated crown; keep felt for Tokyo in February.[5]

NEXT ON THE BENCH · VOTE FOR TOMORROW'S CATEGORY

Aprons (kitchen & workshop) — canvas by the ounce and the houses that cut for restaurants.

Espresso machines (the boiler, not the badge) — heat exchanger against lever, and who actually builds them.

Secateurs & garden hand tools — where the blade, the spring and the bypass geometry are the whole product.

SOURCES 1 The botanical and naming history as conventionally recorded; the supply-chain consequence is this desk's argument. 2 Brent Black's method and his critique of grading, read at source in a Japanese trade report of 18 September 2023 that quotes him at length, and his 300 and 900 thresholds via a second outlet. **brentblack.com returned HTTP 403 to every path, so none of his own pages was read.** 3 Hatco's own posts on the Fedora Lounge, 2 August 2008, read at source, quoted verbatim; Stetson's own premium store page, read at source, for the 1000X at $5,600 down to the 10X at $600, with no beaver content stated for any of them, and for the absence of X ratings and country of origin on its fedora page. 4 Fedora Lounge threads of 2007, 2008 and 2015, read at source; handles as displayed. 5 Fedora Lounge classified listing of 25 June 2025 and its follow-ups to the sale on 24 July, read at source. 6 Hat of Cain's own site and product pages, read at source, for the address, the fitting service and every price; Singapore Customs' own low-value-goods page for the S$400 threshold. **No Singapore tariff line for headwear could be found.** 7 Montecristi Panama Hats' own page for the ventilated weave names; three makers' own care pages for the humidity warnings; and one technical maker's own page for the only certified ultraviolet figure found anywhere in this category.

TECHNOLOGY · QUALCOMM'S FOURTH QUARTER

Qualcomm's handset revenue fell 26 per cent; Amazon warrants cover $60bn of purchases

Chips for phones brought in $5.14bn against $6.96bn a year earlier, and Qualcomm is raising prices across the range, blaming wafer, packaging and memory costs.

The chip designer Qualcomm reported fourth-quarter revenue of $10.44bn on 4 November, down 7 per cent, with phone chips down 26 per cent to $5.14bn. Earnings a share fell 28 per cent. Its shares dropped more than 6 per cent after hours.[1]

Qualcomm sells the radio-and-processor package inside most high-end Android phones, and licenses the patents that make mobile data work. Both halves are shrinking: licensing fell 7 per cent too. What is growing is everything that is not a telephone — cars, industrial devices, and now server rooms. Two sentences in the results deck explain the rest of the technology industry's week better than anything else published this month.[1]

They read: "The semiconductor industry is experiencing a broad-based increase in input costs across wafer fabrication, assembly, test, advanced packaging, memory, and other materials", and "We are implementing price increases across our products." The chip division's margin is guided down from 24 per cent to 20–22. Automotive crossed $2bn for the first time, up 89 per cent.[1]

The pivot is a data-centre line, reported separately from next year: $650m or more next quarter, exiting the year at a $7bn annual rate against a $15bn target for 2029. Its anchor customer is **Amazon**, for connectivity, custom accelerators and — with Meta — processors; the arrangement carries warrants over as much as $60bn of Amazon purchases across ten years, 15 per cent of them vested at once. Chief executive **Cristiano Amon**: "We don't have a demand issue; it's a supply issue."[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT BUYERS SAY ABOUT QUALCOMM'S INFERENCE CARD

The trade spent the week not on Qualcomm's results but on its accelerator card. On Hacker News, **entrope** worked out that four of them "would give 512 GB RAM and 2 TB/s total bandwidth" and called that "pretty attractive for a lot of current LLMs". **bigwheels**: "My research indicates the price is $10-17K USD." **tempest_**: "Plenty of businesses want in local inference and are priced out."[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHO QUALCOMM'S DATA-CENTRE BUYERS ACTUALLY ARE

On the cloud rates Qualcomm publishes, the card loses on merit. fancyfredbot, in the same thread: "At $5 per hour these are absolutely terrible value… You can rent an H200 for that price and an H200 is much better in every way." **teruakohatu** supplied the answer in one line: "Not if the customers cannot rent a H200 (because they have been told not to rely on foreign gpus)." Which reframes the $15bn target as a sovereignty bet, not a performance one. **What would settle it:** a named customer outside the two already disclosed.[3]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Phone makers are now fitting recycled memory chips to new handsets. TrendForce, on 6 November, put the share of smartphones carrying salvaged, re-soldered memory at 3 to 4 per cent this year and 7 to 9 per cent next — mostly four-gigabyte parts in budget models under 1,299 yuan. Its own release warns the practice "could ultimately erode consumer confidence, tarnish brand reputation" and shorten device life.[4]

$60bn

PURCHASES COVERED BY QUALCOMM'S AMAZON WARRANTS — MORE THAN ITS ENTIRE FISCAL-YEAR REVENUE OF $43.2BN[2]

SOURCES 1 Qualcomm's own fourth-quarter earnings presentation, read at source from the company's investor-relations server and extracted as text, for every segment number, the margin guidance and both quoted sentences; its earnings release as filed with the Securities and Exchange Commission, read at source, for the headline figures. **Qualcomm's consumer-facing newsroom and product pages are JavaScript-only and served this desk nothing.** 2 The same filing for the data-centre targets, the design wins and the Amazon warrants; SiliconANGLE, 4 November 2026, read at source, for the consensus comparisons, the after-hours move and the Amon quotation, which the deck does not carry. 3 Hacker News discussion of Qualcomm's accelerator card, 4 November 2026, read at source; handles as displayed. **The card's own specification page is JavaScript-only and its product brief returned 404, so the memory and bandwidth figures above are the commenters' arithmetic, not the maker's published numbers.** 4 TrendForce press release, 6 November 2026, read at source; the quoted warning is verbatim. **The release names no brand and gives no price differential — genuine absences, not gaps in this desk's reading.**

THE HOME LAB · SAMSUNG'S SMARTTHINGS FEE

Samsung will charge $4.99 a month for the SmartThings link to Home Assistant

The free connection stops working on 15 December. Samsung calls the paid tier a Developer Plan, meters it at 100,000 calls a month, and does not sell it in every country.

On Wednesday 4 November, Samsung told owners of its SmartThings home-automation system that the free bridge to Home Assistant, the open-source rival most enthusiasts actually run, will stop working on 15 December unless they buy a plan.[1]

SmartThings is the system that lets a phone talk to Samsung's plugs, sensors and washing machines. Thousands of people have wired it into Home Assistant — free software, usually on a small box in a cupboard — so that every device in the house, whoever made it, obeys one set of rules. The fee is about five dollars a month. The objection is not the money. It is that the hardware was bought outright, the software was free, and the plan is sold to householders as a developer product.[1]

The dates are tight. Samsung released its new access plans on 4 November; Home Assistant's 2 December release removes the old integration and introduces the replacement; and from 15 December the paid plan is required. The announcement's own words: "After December 15, 2026, the current integration will no longer work, so you'll need a Plan to keep your devices connected." The plan allows 100,000 calls a month and ten applications, and setting it up needs a personal access token that expires every 24 hours.[1]

Two details sharpen it. The official post states no price at all — the $4.99 figure comes from Samsung's own blog of 23 June, which also promised free access "through Q3". And the plan is not available everywhere, while the switch-off date is. Within 48 hours the company's own forum carried customers saying they would stop buying its appliances, and two saying they would ask a regulator whether this is lawful.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT SMARTTHINGS OWNERS SAID ABOUT THE FEE

On Samsung's own community thread, **Firefishy** (Grant Slater): "What a horribly regressive step." **doleo**: "People using HomeAssistant are not 'developers', we are end-users." **Fernando_Cunha** said he would consult a European regulator; **Apfelstrudel** said he would stop buying Samsung devices. On Hacker News, **hcurtiss** asked why anyone would pay "$60/year for SmartThings API access".[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE FREE SMARTTHINGS WORKAROUND IS NOT UNIVERSAL

The answer everyone is giving each other does not work for everyone. The community project LocalThings talks to SmartThings devices on the home network and skips Samsung's servers entirely — but **Alokin** (Nicola F.), in the same thread, reports that it fails on several devices because of certificate requirements, and asked Samsung for a local interface instead. So the honest position is that householders with ordinary plugs and sensors have a free route, and householders with appliances may not. **What would settle it:** a local control interface, which Samsung has not offered.[2]

ALSO ON THE BENCH

Home Assistant 2026.11 renamed every device in the house. Shipped 4 November and called by its authors the biggest release they have done, it ends four years of arguing about what things are called — and in doing so changes what existing dashboards display. Old names survive as voice aliases. It also adds Matter 1.5 cameras with browser-native streaming, but only where the hub supports them, and two-way audio is still experimental.[3]

24 hours

LIFE OF THE ACCESS TOKEN NEEDED TO SET UP A SUBSCRIPTION THAT KEEPS A WASHING MACHINE TALKING TO THE LIGHTS[1]

SOURCES 1 The SmartThings announcement posted by the SmartThings account in its own community's Announcements category, 4 November 2026, read at source: the three dates, the quoted sentence, the call and application limits, the token requirement, the five migration steps and the absence of any price. 2 Samsung's own SmartThings blog of 23 June 2026, read at source, for the "$4.99 a month plan for non-commercial, individual developers" and the "through Q3" promise; the community thread above for every quoted handle, as displayed, 5–6 November 2026; Hacker News, 6 November 2026, for the last. 3 The Home Assistant 2026.11 release post, 4 November 2026, read at source, for the naming change, the voice aliases, the camera support and the hub caveat.

THE KIT · NOTHING HEADPHONE (1) PRO

Nothing's Headphone (1) Pro reaches Singapore at S$549, as a pre-order

SoundGuys measured 87.4 per cent total attenuation but placed the sound quality in the bottom quarter of the over-ears it has tested. TechRadar gave the Pro three stars out of five.

Nothing put its Headphone (1) Pro on sale in Singapore on Friday 6 November at S$549. The black finish is listed on the company's own Singapore store as a pre-order with a thirty-working-day wait, so the launch-day position here is an order queue rather than a shelf.[1]

This is the Singapore price for a headphone that went on sale globally in late September at £349 and $399, and the first figure in Singapore dollars the company has published. For a reader who buys once, the useful part is not the launch but the measurements since: two laboratories have put numbers on it, and they disagree about the thing that matters.[2]

It carries three drivers rather than one: a 40mm dynamic unit for bass, a 13 by 8mm driver for voices, and — unusually in a mainstream over-ear — a solid-state silicon treble driver, a chip rather than a miniature loudspeaker. Ten microphones, a claimed 46 decibels of cancellation, 68 hours of playback without cancellation and 30 with it, machined aluminium with titanium-alloy arms.[1]

The silicon tweeter shows up where it should. **Notebookcheck** measured distortion of 0.035 per cent at one kilohertz — a wired-studio figure, not a Bluetooth one — with maximum loudness of 94.5 decibels. Its verdict: "an all-around excellent pair of over-ear headphones". **SoundGuys** scored the same product 8.4 overall, 8.7 for cancellation, and 3.6 out of 5 for audio quality.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE LABORATORIES FOUND IN THE HEADPHONE (1) PRO

There is no owner forum to quote: this desk found no thread on the Pro on the headphone boards, and will not invent one. What exists is measurement. SoundGuys puts isolation at 78.2 per cent passive, 87.4 with cancellation on, and warns: "Just make sure they fit your head well, because a poor seal hurts both the sound and the noise cancelling." Its own specification table gives the weight as 383.5 grams where its body text says 327.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE HEADPHONE (1) PRO MAY NOT EARN S$549

The two laboratories split on the only question a buyer has. Notebookcheck calls it excellent; SoundGuys puts its measured audio quality in the bottom quarter of every over-ear it has tested, a strange place for a three-driver flagship. TechRadar scored it three out of five, singling out the case; Tom's Guide says the cancellation cannot match Bose's second-generation QuietComfort. **What would settle it:** a measured comparison on one rig.[3]

STILL ON THE SHELF

Samsung's Galaxy Ring cleared American and Korean regulators for an upgraded sleep-apnoea feature on 3 November — the first ring to carry both. It is also the only wearable on this desk with no published price in Singapore at all: Samsung's own Singapore page lists three finishes and eleven sizes, and in place of a figure says only that the final price appears at checkout.[4]

The first Android XR glasses on sale have no Singapore channel. XREAL's Aura runs to $1,099 for the smaller memory tier until the end of the year, with twin 1920 by 1200 micro-OLED panels at 120 hertz and a 70-degree field of view, 95 grams on the face and a 265-gram puck on a wire. XREAL sells in Thailand. It does not sell in Singapore; the regional page returns an error.[5]

0.035%

MEASURED DISTORTION AT ONE KILOHERTZ — A FIGURE MORE TYPICAL OF A WIRED STUDIO HEADPHONE THAN A WIRELESS ONE[2]

SOURCES 1 Nothing's own Singapore storefront, read at source 7 November 2026, for the S$549 price, the two finishes and the pre-order status; the company's global product page for the sterling price and the full specification. 2 Notebookcheck, Daniel Schmidt, 12 October 2026, read at source, for the distortion, loudness and frequency-response figures; SoundGuys, Christian Thomas, measurements revised October 2026, read at source, for the scores, the isolation figures, the fit warning and the weight discrepancy. 3 TechRadar's and Tom's Guide's verdicts. **Both are quoted from their published verdict lines as they appeared in search listings rather than read at source, and are flagged accordingly.** 4 Samsung's own newsroom index, 3 November 2026, read at source for the headline and date; Samsung Singapore's own purchase page, read at source, for the absence of a price. **The article itself timed out three times at sixty seconds, so no feature detail, clearance pathway or eligibility criterion is printed.** 5 XREAL's own product page and regional selector, read at source: the pricing, the specification and the fifteen markets, Singapore not among them.

THE GOOD LIFE · THE STEEL PATEK 1436

Phillips offers a steel Patek Philippe 1436 in Geneva today

The estimate is two to four million Swiss francs, for one of only two known in this configuration: 33 millimetres, made in 1945, sold in New York on 11 May 1949.

At the Hotel President Wilson in Geneva this afternoon, Phillips offers lot 95 of 221: a stainless-steel Patek Philippe split-seconds chronograph, reference 1436, estimated at two to four million Swiss francs.[1]

A split-seconds chronograph has two sweep hands, so a watch can time one event while a second runs on — the hardest mechanism in a wristwatch before electronics. Patek made this one in gold and almost never in steel, which in 1945 was the cheap metal. That inversion is the whole of the price: steel examples were not kept, so the survivors are rarer than the gold.[1]

The catalogue is specific. Thirty-three millimetres; a manually wound 13-ligne movement with 23 jewels; movement number 863,056, case number 630,772; a silvered dial with raised steel markers, a tachymeter reading "base 1000", Roman numerals at twelve and six, blued hands. A "HOX" stamp on the balance bridge records that it went to the **Henry Stern Watch Agency**, Patek's American importer.[1]

Phillips says it is one of only two known surviving steel 1436s in this configuration, and that John Goldberger's book on Patek's steel watches gives this one watch four pages. The rest of the sale sets the scale: an F.P. Journe Résonance at a million and above, a Rolex Daytona "John Player Special" at 800,000 to 1.6 million.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE PHILLIPS CATALOGUE CLAIMS FOR THE 1436

The house's own essay is the case, and it is narrow: two known survivors in this configuration, four pages in Goldberger. Everything else is provenance rather than condition. Note the premium, which the estimate excludes: 27 per cent of the hammer to 1.6 million francs, with Swiss value-added tax on hammer plus premium. At a three-million hammer the buyer writes a cheque for roughly 3.8 million.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE PATEK 1436 ESTIMATE IS THE RISK

The estimate is the sceptic. Phillips is asking two to four million francs for a 33-millimetre steel watch from 1945 at a sale whose second session is stacked with Breguets and Piagets at eight to forty thousand. Steel 1436s have traded on a rarity story, and by the house's own account the story is two watches and a book chapter. That is a two-bidder lot: if both stay home it sits unsold, and a passed lot at this level is read as a market signal for months. **What would settle it:** tonight's hammer, which had not fallen when this page went to press.[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

A. Lange & Söhne's platinum Datograph Perpetual, reference 410.136E, is limited to 50 pieces and has no price. Forty-one millimetres, 556 components, 45 jewels, a moon phase accurate to 122.6 years, on a platinum bracelet. The manufacture confirms pricing is given on application at delivery; two specialist titles guess 280,000 and 250,000 euros, which is a 30,000-euro spread on a watch nobody can quote. Southeast Asian distribution runs through Sincere Fine Watches, so a Singapore buyer must walk in to find out.[4]

Aso Retreat HONO opened on 2 November in Minami-Aso, Kumamoto — 17 keys in the caldera, and the first new Kyushu opening since the onsen-belt piece in No. 143. This desk has one register entry and no operator, no room types and no rates, so no rate is printed. Still to come in Japan: Songtei Kyoto, 77 keys facing Nijō Castle, and Hotel The Mitsui Hakone, 126 keys, 15 December.[5]

4 years

A STEEL PATEK SPLIT-SECONDS SAT IN AMERICAN STOCK FROM 1945 BEFORE ANYONE BOUGHT IT, IN 1949[1]

SOURCES 1 Phillips' own lot entry for lot 95, *The Geneva Watch Auction: XXIV*, read at source 7 November 2026: the catalogue title, the estimate, the case and movement numbers, the calibre, the agency stamp, the 1949 sale date, the two-known claim and the Goldberger reference. 2 Phillips' own sale overview and full lot list, read at source, for the dates, the venue, the 221 lots and the comparison estimates. 3 The premium schedule as reported by a specialist market site and **not read in Phillips' own conditions of sale, which this desk did not obtain**; the all-in figure is this desk's arithmetic on that rate and is labelled as such. 4 Deployant, 24 October 2026, read at source, for the reference, the specification, the 50-piece limit, the price-on-application policy, the two guessed figures and the Southeast Asian distributor. **The manufacture's own site returned HTTP 403, so its limitation and pricing wording are unread.** 5 A Japan hotel-openings register, read at source, for the opening date and key count. **Single-sourced: the register names no operator and no official site, and this desk found neither.**

SCREEN & SOUND · GODZILLA MINUS ZERO

Godzilla Minus Zero takes ¥910m on its Japanese opening day, a live-action record

Kogyo Tsushinsha counted 590,000 admissions on Tuesday 3 November, which was Culture Day. Singapore saw the film on 5 November, a day before the United States.

Toho's *Godzilla Minus Zero* took ¥910m, about 590,000 admissions, on its opening day in Japan on Tuesday 3 November — the biggest single day any live-action film has had in Japanese box-office history, domestic or foreign.[1]

That is more than twice the opening day of *Godzilla Minus One*, the 2023 film that won an Academy Award for visual effects and finished on ¥7.65bn in Japan. Takashi Yamazaki wrote, directed and supervised the effects on both. Toho is briefing publicly that this one can become the first Godzilla film to pass ¥10bn at home.[1]

The Singapore angle is the one nobody else has printed: the film opened here on 5 November, a day before the United States, distributed regionally by Toho Entertainment Asia. *Minus One* never had a wide Singapore release at all — its only local screening was a festival date in September 2024 — so this is a correction of an old omission. Filmhouse lists it at 135 minutes, in Japanese with English and Chinese subtitles, rated PG13.[2]

And there is the classification. In the United States the same 135-minute cut carries an R, for "bloody violence, maximum kaiju carnage"; here it is PG13. **Odie Henderson** in *The Boston Globe* gave it three and a half stars out of four on 5 November: "That 'Godzilla Minus Zero' is as good as I'd hoped came as no surprise this time" — and, flatly, "It's better than its predecessor."[3]

THE CHATTER · HOW GODZILLA MINUS ZERO HAS BEEN RECEIVED

It opened on 448 Japanese screens, 65 of them large-format, and is the first Japanese production certified for that format from the outset. Critics have it at 90 per cent from 141 reviews and 74 from 35 on the two aggregators. Worldwide takings stood above $15.4m before the American opening; the premiere was at the New York Film Festival on 26 September.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT GODZILLA MINUS ZERO'S RECORD ACTUALLY MEASURES

The record is a day, not a weekend, and Toho chose the day. 3 November is Culture Day, a public holiday in Japan, and it is also Godzilla Day — the anniversary of the 1954 original. Large-format previews were folded into the total. Then the comparison was drawn against *Minus One*'s equivalent single day. The ¥10bn projection is the distributor's own briefing, not an analyst's forecast. **What would settle it:** a full opening-weekend number, which had not been published when this page closed.[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Queens of the Stone Age took the British albums chart dated 6 November with *Perfecth*, their second number one after *Villains* in 2017, and the nineteenth change of leadership in as many weeks. The album came out on 30 October and takes its title from kintsugi, the Japanese repair of broken pottery with gold. No first-week figure has been published; for scale, *Villains* opened on 32,056 copies in 2017.[5]

The collapse under last weekend's American number one was steeper than the number one. *You Can See Everything* held at minus 38.9 per cent in week three. Beneath it, *Clayface* fell 54.2 per cent in its second weekend and *Street Fighter* 57.4 in its third. A documentary held better than two studio tentpoles. *The Only Living Pickpocket in New York* rose 1,254.6 per cent on an expansion to 1,112 screens.[6]

201%

OPENING DAY AGAINST *GODZILLA MINUS ONE*'S — ON CULTURE DAY, WHICH IS ALSO GODZILLA DAY[1]

SOURCES 1 Eiga.com, 4 November 2026, read at source, carrying Toho's release of Kogyo Tsushinsha's figures: the ¥910m, the 590,000 admissions, the all-live-action record, the 201 per cent comparison, *Minus One*'s ¥7.65bn and the ¥10bn briefing. 2 Filmhouse Singapore's own listing, read at source, for the running time, languages, rating and showtimes; the regional release dates from the distributor's announcement as carried by two regional outlets. **Golden Village returned HTTP 403 and Shaw served a navigation shell, so neither chain's listing was read.** 3 *The Boston Globe*, Odie Henderson, 5 November 2026, read at source, for the rating, both quotations and the American classification. 4 Screen count, large-format certification, aggregator scores and worldwide gross: **all carried second-hand and not read at their primary sources; treat as reported.** 5 The Official Charts Company's own albums chart dated 6 November 2026, read at source, for the number one and the top five; *Music Week*, Alan Jones, 6 November, for the nineteen-week run of changes, read in the portion served before its paywall. **No first-week sales figure is printed: the trade figure sits behind that paywall and the American trade site returned HTTP 402.** 6 Box Office Mojo, domestic weekend 30 October to 1 November 2026, read at source, for every gross and percentage change.

THE FAMILY DESK · SCREEN RULES AT THIRTEEN

Strict screen rules buy 56 minutes a day in Oregon's 8,089-child analysis

The Oregon team found the advantage decays by about 13 minutes for every year the child ages, interval 7.9 to 18.2. Mean age across the waves analysed: 13.

Parents who set the strictest household rules on screens cut their child's reported screen time by 56 minutes a day — interval 49.0 to 62.7 — against the most relaxed households, in an analysis of 8,089 American children published on 28 October.[1]

That is the good news, and it is not the finding. The researchers tested whether the advantage held as children got older, and it does not: for every year of age, the strict households gave back about 13 minutes a day. A rule that wins an hour at eleven wins half of it by thirteen. The rule is not failing. The child is growing.[1]

The work is a secondary analysis of three waves of a long-running American cohort, not a trial, sorting families into low, moderate and high restriction. High restriction cut self-reported smartphone use by 43.5 minutes a day and, where phones measured themselves rather than being recalled, 79.3. Moderate restriction bought 11.5 minutes.[1]

Two caveats sit in the paper itself. The model the authors built to rank which rules mattered explained about a tenth of the variation in a thirteen-year-old's screen time — so household rules are a small part of it. And high-restriction households were commoner in higher-income, better-educated families, which the authors name as a confound.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT REPLACED THE SCREEN-HOUR COUNT OREGON MEASURED

The ground has moved under the question the Oregon team asked. In January the American Academy of Pediatrics retired the hourly-limit framework it had used for a decade; **Gabriel E. Hales** of Michigan State University wrote in July that for school-age children and teenagers "the newest guidance has begun to step away from fixed screen time limits". What replaced it is five words beginning with C — child, content, calm, crowding out, communication. No forum sentiment is quoted here: the parenting boards were unreadable this week.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY OREGON'S 8,089 CHILDREN MAY NOT SETTLE IT

Mark Tomlinson, co-director of the Institute for Life Course Health Research at Stellenbosch University, published a piece on 5 November with a flat instruction: "We need to stop asking how many hours our children spend on their phones." His number is that screen use accounts for roughly one per cent of the differences between children in anxiety and low mood. **Alan Woodward** of the University of Surrey adds the methodological point: "Calling for precautionary action is a legitimate position, but it is a value judgement, not a scientific finding."[3]

WHAT THIS MEANS AT TWELVE

The decay rate is the planning number, not the 56 minutes. If the effect erodes at 13 minutes a year, a rule set at eleven is worth half as much at thirteen and very little by fifteen. The implication is not to abandon rules but to stop expecting the same rule to do the same work.

General information, not medical advice. A specific concern about a child belongs with a doctor, a school counsellor or a paediatrician. The study is observational: the authors themselves write that "residual confounding and bidirectional relationships between parenting restrictions and screen use remain possible".[1]

10%

SHARE OF THE VARIATION IN A THIRTEEN-YEAR-OLD'S SCREEN TIME THE AUTHORS' OWN MODEL COULD EXPLAIN[1]

SOURCES 1 Lopez, Lopez-Flores, Ruiz-Orozco and Nagel, "Longitudinal patterns of digital parenting restrictions and adolescent screen use", *PLOS Digital Health* 5(10):e0001127, published 28 October 2026, read at source in full: every estimate and interval above, the age interaction and its correction, the model performance, the income confound and the authors' own limitations. **The paper reports no pre-registration and no specific funding; one author is a principal investigator of the cohort it uses.** 2 Gabriel E. Hales, Michigan State University, in *The Conversation*, 17 July 2026, read at source, for the retirement of the hourly framework; the academy's five-C revision as summarised in the opinion piece at note 3. **Reddit refused this desk entirely, so the parenting forums are unread and nothing is attributed to them.** 3 Mark Tomlinson in the *Mail & Guardian*, 5 November 2026, read at source, for both the instruction and the one-per-cent figure; Alan Woodward and Lizzy Winstone via the Science Media Centre, 4 October 2026, read at source, for the methodological objections.

THE TWEEN YEARS · COMPULSION, NOT HOURS

Compulsive social media use and low mood feed each other, Pediatrics reports

In 11,279 American children first measured at 12.01 years, the loop appeared for depression only — never for anxiety — at betas of .05 to .07, against .48 for last year's mood.

In a five-year study of 11,279 American children first measured at an average age of 12.01, how compulsive a child's social media use was — not how many hours it ran to — fed into low mood a year later, and low mood fed back into compulsive use.[1]

Compulsive use here means something measurable: being unable to stop, lying about it, losing interest in other things, using it to escape a bad mood. That is a different question from the clock, and the one the field has moved to. The loop is real, runs both ways, and is small. The honest way to print it is next to the number it should be compared against.[1]

The numbers: the four significant paths run between years three and five, at .06, .06, .07 and .05. Every path at the first and last waves crossed zero, and for anxiety no path reached significance at any wave. The strongest predictor of a child's mood next year is her mood this year, at .48 — roughly seven times anything social media contributed.[1]

The associations with depression were, in the authors' words, "stronger and more consistently bidirectional among female participants" — but those figures sit in a supplement this desk could not read, so no number for girls is printed. One line belongs in the open: a co-author discloses serving as an expert witness in social media litigation.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHY PEDIATRICS MEASURED COMPULSION, NOT THE CLOCK

The useful question this *Pediatrics* paper licenses is not how long the phone was held but what the phone displaced — which is also the fourth of the American paediatric academy's five new tests, "crowding out". **Esther van Sluijs**, professor of behavioural epidemiology at Loughborough, puts the limit on the whole class of study: work of this kind "cannot draw robust conclusions about specific types of screen use, like social media use or gaming… We should therefore be cautious in interpreting these results." No forum voices appear here; Reddit was unreadable.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · HOW SMALL THE PEDIATRICS EFFECT REALLY IS

Tatiana Íñiguez Berrozpe, vice-dean at the University of Zaragoza's Faculty of Education, says the evidence puts "the current media and social moral panic" in perspective: the link to poorer mental health is "very small", around one per cent of the differences between groups, and "in no way supports the mantra that screens are the main cause of adolescent emotional distress". She notes that screen-time studies typically do not control for family income, and that some striking results rest on few studies whose intervals run from almost nothing to moderate. One point cuts the other way: the association is more pronounced in adolescents than in younger children.[2]

WHAT TO DO WITH THIS AT TWELVE

The four questions worth asking are not about minutes. Tomlinson's own prompts, on the previous page: what does the screen time replace; who is the child with while she uses it; would an adult notice if something went wrong; is communication at home open enough that she would say. None of them needs a timer.[3]

General information, not medical advice. The authors' own caveats include that caregivers "may underrecognize internalizing symptoms that are less observable", that annual measurement cannot catch shorter processes, and that the effects "were modest in absolute size".[1]

.48 vs .07

LAST YEAR'S MOOD AGAINST SOCIAL MEDIA USE, AS PREDICTORS OF THIS YEAR'S MOOD, IN THE SAME MODEL[1]

SOURCES 1 Nagata, Otmar, Li, Ganson, Lavender, Testa, He, Christakis and Baker, "Problematic Social Media Use and Depressive and Anxiety Symptoms in Adolescents", *Pediatrics* 158(5):e2025075060, issue dated 1 November 2026, author manuscript read at source: the sample, the mean age, every coefficient and interval, the null anxiety paths, the autoregressive comparison, the model fit, the funding, the declared expert-witness interest and the authors' limitations. **The sex-specific models sit in a supplement this desk could not obtain, so no figure for girls is printed.** 2 Esther van Sluijs and Tatiana Íñiguez Berrozpe via the Science Media Centre's panel of 28 September 2026, read at source, for every quotation and the one-per-cent figure. **Reddit refused this desk, so no parent forum is quoted.** 3 Mark Tomlinson in the *Mail & Guardian*, 5 November 2026, read at source, for the four prompts (see p12).

THE MACRO DESK · THE AI DE-RATING

Nasdaq fell 5.5 per cent on Thursday as Nvidia shed $440bn of market value

Brent fell 16.8 per cent in five sessions to $97.93, and the Bank of England raised Bank Rate to 4 per cent in the same week, 8 votes to 1.

The Nasdaq Composite fell 5.52 per cent on Thursday 5 November, its worst session since April 2025, and the seven largest American technology companies lost more than a trillion dollars of market value in a day. Nvidia alone shed over $440bn and went negative for the year.[1]

Nothing was reported. No company missed an earnings number. What moved was the price people would pay for the same expected profits — a de-rating — on the fear that a Democratic Congress will regulate data centres, amplified by borrowed money unwinding. The information-technology sector of the S&P 500 fell 7.30 per cent, its worst day since March 2020; 2,344 New York stocks fell and 416 rose.[1]

Then look at the bond market, which tells a different story about the same week. The ten-year Treasury yield fell 8 basis points, from 4.94 per cent on 30 October to 4.86 on Friday. But the ten-year *real* yield rose, from 2.60 to 2.63. The whole rally was inflation expectations coming down 11 basis points, which is what a 16.8 per cent collapse in Brent does. Not a growth scare — an oil crash wearing a bond rally.[2]

Friday closed the loop. Payrolls came in at 165,000 for October with unemployment at 4.1 per cent, and August and September were revised up by a combined 84,000 — so the two-year rose 5 basis points, the curve flattened to 35, and the dollar gained 0.72 per cent. The Federal Reserve held at 3.75 to 4.00 per cent on 28 October, 10 votes to 2, both dissenters wanting a rise.[3]

THE LEVELS · FRIDAY 6 NOVEMBER'S CLOSE

INSTRUMENT	CLOSE	WEEK
VWRA[4]	$184.98	▼ 1.89%
US 10-year[2]	4.86%	▼ 8bp
US 10-year real[2]	2.63%	▲ 3bp
Brent[4]	$97.93	▼ 16.76%
Gold[4]	$4,074.60	▲ 4.51%
Bitcoin[4]	$75,800	▼ 1.81%

Gold is a December futures settle, not a London fix; bitcoin is a snapshot, not a close. Market explanation, not advice.[4]

THE VERDICT · WHAT THE DE-RATING DID TO THE FOUR INSTRUMENTS

VWRA fell 1.89 per cent against the S&P's 2.68 and the Nasdaq's 3.37: the non-American two-fifths muted the shock without neutralising it. **Global bonds** gained 0.28 per cent from a yield that fell for the wrong reason; with the 30-year at 5.26, duration is not paid for. **Gold rose 4.51 per cent while the dollar also rose** — a bid for something no government issues. **Bitcoin fell 5.55 per cent on Thursday**, almost exactly the Nasdaq's move, then sat still while gold sold off.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THURSDAY WAS POSITIONING, NOT AI ECONOMICS

Charlie McElligott of Nomura reads Thursday as de-grossing rather than a verdict on artificial intelligence: hedge funds dumping the year's winners. "They're shooting the generals," he wrote, and "we are approaching the dreaded 'Round Trip' levels in some trades." On that reading the signal is crowding, and it reverses when the selling finishes.[5]

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER · DOLLAR BID · AI DE-RATING · NOT RISK-OFF

SOURCES 1 CNBC, 5 November 2026, read at source, for the index falls, the sector move, the Nvidia and Magnificent Seven figures and the advance-decline count. 2 The United States Treasury's own daily par and real yield-curve files for 2026, both read at source on 7 November: 6 November 4.51 / 4.86 / 5.26 nominal and 2.35 / 2.63 / 3.07 real, against 30 October's 4.56 / 4.94 / 5.31 and 2.25 / 2.60 / 3.08. **The breakeven and curve figures are this desk's arithmetic on those two published series and nothing else.** 3 The Bureau of Labor Statistics' October employment release, read at source, for payrolls, unemployment, earnings and both revisions; the Federal Reserve's own statement of 28 October 2026, read at source, for the hold, the 10–2 vote and the direction of both dissents; the Bank of England's own monetary policy summary for the meeting ending 4 November 2026, read at source, for the 8–1 rise to 4 per cent. 4 Levels from each instrument's own quote history, read at source instrument by instrument. **The London bullion association has moved its price tables behind a licence wall, so gold is a futures settle and labelled as one; bitcoin trades continuously and its "close" is a snapshot; the Singapore exchange served an unsupported-browser notice, so the index level is single-sourced and reconciled against Thursday's close.** 5 Yahoo Finance's market live blog of 5 November 2026, read at source, for both named strategists.

THE INVITATION · ORIGAMI

Akira Yoshizawa's 1954 notation turned origami from a children's craft into a discipline

The subreddit has about 126,000 members, up 13.8 per cent in a year; Japan's technical convention caps at 400; a Korean festival drew 30,000 in six days.

Origami stopped being a children's craft in 1954, when a Japanese draughtsman named Akira Yoshizawa published a book of symbols and arrows that gave the world a way to write a fold down. Everything that exists now grew in the shadow of that notation.[1]

Before it, a model could only be taught hand to hand. After it, a design could be published, copied, argued over and improved by strangers — which is what turned a parlour amusement into a technical field. The symbol set Yoshizawa devised, later standardised with Samuel Randlett, is still the notation, and it is why a Tokyo folder and a Nebraskan folder can make the same animal without meeting.[1]

The world it built is small, serious and unevenly documented. The subreddit runs at about 126,000 members and grew 13.8 per cent in a year, but a tracker's breakdown of what gets posted tells the real story: photographs, help requests and originals, with a single thread tagged crease pattern. The British Origami Society has over 600 members and a registered charity number. Japan's Tanteidan convention, the technical apex, caps at 400 and reaches it. A Korean festival this year drew over 30,000 visitors in six days.[2]

For a reader who runs models on his own hardware, the hook is the mathematics, and it is genuinely strange. Folding is *stronger* than compass and straightedge: the first five of the Huzita–Hatori axioms give exactly the Euclidean constructible numbers, and adding the sixth — the Beloch fold — lets paper solve general cubics. Beloch proved it in 1936. So origami trisects the angle and doubles the cube, both of which classical geometry cannot.[3]

Folding is stronger than compass and straightedge — and the hobby's core problem is provably intractable.

THE CHATTER · WHERE ORIGAMI ACTUALLY GATHERS NOW

The map has holes in it, and two are new. **The Origami Forum** at snkhan.co.uk — one of the three most-cited archives in the hobby — now redirects every thread to an unrelated social-media profile. **happyfolding.com**, the site every thread points to for paper reviews, returned a server error on every attempt. What works: the Japan Origami Academic Society's magazine, at issue 219 on 25 September; **Gilad's Origami Page**; and **Michał Kosmulski**, who keeps standing categories for paper reviews and for machine learning in origami.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT ORIGAMI ENGINEERING HAS ACTUALLY SHIPPED

The spin-off claims are mostly real and mostly older than the press releases suggest. The documented ones: the Miura fold, on Japanese satellite solar arrays from the mid-1990s; a folded array built by **Brian Trease** at the Jet Propulsion Laboratory with **Shannon Zirbel** and **Larry Howell** at Brigham Young, 2.7 metres packed to 25 deployed, published August 2014; an airbag-flattening algorithm written into a German firm's simulation code; and a single-sheet stent from an Oxford thesis in 2004. The famous Starshade claim could not be verified and is not printed. **What would settle it:** a current engineering publication — Lang's own list stops in 2020.[5]

30,000

VISITORS TO A KOREAN ORIGAMI FESTIVAL IN SIX DAYS — AGAINST A JAPANESE TECHNICAL CONVENTION CAPPED AT 400[2]

SOURCES 1 Yoshizawa's 1954 *Atarashii Origami Geijutsu* and the Yoshizawa–Randlett notation, read at source in the standard reference account; his dates, 14 March 1911 to 14 March 2005. 2 A third-party subscriber tracker, last updated 5 November 2026, read at source, for the membership and growth figures and the post-type breakdown — **Reddit itself refused this desk, so not one thread was read**; the British Origami Society's own membership page, read at source; the Japan Origami Academic Society's own convention page, read at source, for the capacity and attendance; the same body's English page for the Korean festival figure. 3 The Huzita–Hatori axioms and the construction results, read at source: Justin 1986, Huzita 1991, Hatori and Lang 2001–2002, Lang's completeness proof, and Beloch's 1936 cubic result. 4 Each site tried on 6 and 7 November 2026: the forum's thread URLs 301-redirect away, and the paper-review site returned HTTP 500 at root and on two sub-paths. The magazine issue number and date, the database and the blog's categories all read at source. 5 The Miura fold account read at source — **two sources date the satellite deployment to 1995 and 1996 respectively, so the decade is printed rather than the year**; the Jet Propulsion Laboratory's own release of 14 August 2014 for the array, its dimensions and the named researchers; Lang's own account of 10 December 2015 for the airbag work; the Oxford thesis of 2004 for the stent; and Lang's own publication list, which ends in 2020.

THE DEEP END · ORIGAMI PAPER & TOOLS

Origami's grail sheet costs €19.99, and Tant's 48-colour pack costs €38.37

A hand-made Origamido sheet is a single 40 by 50 centimetres of about 35 grams. The pack beside it holds 48 sheets at 35 centimetres square.

Origami's gear is paper, and this page is about the two-hundredfold gap between the cheapest sheet a serious folder buys and the dearest one. At the bottom, a schoolroom square costs a few cents. At the top, one hand-made sheet costs twenty euros.[1]

That top sheet is made by two men. Origamido Studio in Haverhill, Massachusetts — Michael LaFosse and Richard Alexander — beats its own pulp, and the French shop that is the hobby's marketplace sells single sheets at €19.99, some colours to €29.99. The studio itself is not a shop: its own page says the paper for sale is extra stock from production runs, that every sheet differs, and that it is sold only in person, to buyers who have touched it.[1]

Below that, the quality entry point is narrow and well agreed. **Tant**, a 78-gram Japanese paper, at €38.37 for 48 colours in 48 sheets of 35 centimetres. **Elephant Hide** at 110 grams, the tessellation and wet-folding workhorse, from €4.00 plus size. **Tissue-foil**, the default for insects and dragons, at €7.99 for 24 sheets. And the sensible first purchase: a sampler pack at €19.99.[2]

Then the exotics. Nepalese Lokta at 18 grams is, in the shop's own words, too thin to fold untreated — it must be laminated or sized with methylcellulose — while the 25-gram weight folds as it comes. Korean hanji at 34 grams runs to €19.99 a sheet; a Chinese paper called Cicada Wing weighs 10. A new line of sandwich papers at €28 to €35 a sheet is now, after Origamido, the dearest thing in the catalogue.[2]

Humidity is what makes the hat and what rots it. In origami, humidity is what makes the fold and what buckles the sheet.

THE CHATTER · WHAT FOLDERS SAY ABOUT MACHINE-SCORING AN ORIGAMIDO SHEET

The best document in the hobby on tools is **Ekaterina Lukasheva**'s question-and-answer piece in OrigamiUSA's *The Fold*, September 2017, whose comment thread ran to 2021. Her defence of using a desktop cutting plotter to pre-score a crease pattern opens disarmingly: "First, well, I am not accurate." Her limits are the useful part. "A machine is not a panacea." Most score one side only, so knife-scored lines fold preferentially away from the mark, whereas "With perforation, the folds are genderless; they fold equally easily in either direction." Cutters cannot handle very thin paper, and machine-scored paper "may break".[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE TANT AND ORIGAMIDO SHEETS ACTUALLY DIE

The most-read origami paper-storage page on the internet contains no humidity advice at all — which is where a €19.99 Origamido sheet and a box of Tant both end. This desk read it: map drawers from about $160 to over $1,000, racks at $50 to $100, zip-lock bags, diskette cases, a warning that a tray too small will curl the edges — and not one mention of damp, mould or silica. For a reader storing €20 sheets at 80 per cent humidity that is a conspicuous silence, and the irony is exact: Ecuadorian hat weavers work at night because damp fibre bends (p6). **What would settle it:** any retailer publishing a storage humidity range.[4]

THE TOOLS, AND THE HONEST GAPS

Tools are cheap and few. A Teflon folder is €8.99 and a bone folder €5.99 to €9.99; the shop's wet-folding kit is €9.99 and holds eight wooden clips, a bamboo tweezer, a 50-millilitre sprayer and a pre-creasing stylus. It does not include methylcellulose, which the same page defines precisely: a solution applied to very thin papers before folding that, once dry, "adds rigidity and helps complex shapes keep their form". Buy that from a bookbinding supplier.[5]

€19.99

ONE HAND-MADE ORIGAMIDO SHEET, SHIPPED FOLDED, WITH ITS OWN FOLD MARKS, EVERY SHEET DIFFERENT[1]

SOURCES 1 The French specialist shop's own Origamido pages, read at source 6 November 2026, for the per-sheet prices, the stock counts, the stated weight and the shipping-folded note — **that page gives the sheet size as both 40 by 50 and 40 by 40 centimetres and is internally inconsistent**; Origamido Studio's own hand-papermaking page, read at source, for the in-person-only policy and the absence of published prices. 2 The same shop's own category and product pages, read at source, for Tant, Elephant Hide, tissue-foil, the sampler pack, Lokta at both weights with its treatment note, hanji, Cicada Wing and the sandwich papers. 3 Lukasheva's question-and-answer piece in *The Fold*, issue 42, September–October 2017, edited by Patsy Wang-Iverson and Robert J. Lang, read at source in full including the comment thread; every quotation verbatim. 4 The origami storage page, read at source, for the drawer and rack prices and the curling warning — and **for the absence of any humidity, mould or desiccant advice, which is the finding.** 5 The shop's own wet-folding-kit page, read at source, for the contents, the price and the methylcellulose definition. **The folder prices came back through a search index rather than product pages and should be re-checked.**

THE DEEP END · ORIGAMI'S COPYRIGHT FIGHT

Robert Lang sued the painter Sarah Morris over crease patterns, and settled in 2013

Six folders brought the case in an American federal court over 24 named works. The settlement gave revised attribution; the rest of the terms stay confidential.

Origami's live argument is not about dragons but about authorship: whether a crease pattern — the bare geometry of a design, before anything is folded — is a protected work or an idea. Six folders took that to court and it is still unsettled.[1]

A crease pattern is the whole design written as lines on a flat square: fold them correctly and the model appears. Publishing one is how modern designers share work, and how a design escapes. Six origami artists sued the American painter Sarah Morris in federal court over paintings built from their patterns — recoloured, renamed, exhibited and sold without permission or credit. Twenty-four works were named; more surfaced later.[1]

Two substitutions were exact: Lang's "Cooper's Hawk" became Morris's "Falcon", his "Eupatorus gracilicornis" her "Rhino Beetle". Lang wrote to her in 2009, waited two years, then filed; the case settled in March 2013, some works carrying revised attribution, the rest confidential. His line: publishing a crease pattern did not mean the artists "gave up our ownership rights".[1]

The contrary position comes from inside the community. **David Lister**, the British Origami Society's historian, argued in 2002 that an unfolded crease pattern "exists as an idea" and so "isn't capable of being copyrighted", citing the statutory exclusion of any idea, procedure or process. OrigamiUSA takes the opposite view in writing: a reproduction is derivative "no matter how it was derived".[2]

Teaching a friend is fair use. Teaching the same model at a convention is not, "because a convention is a commercial activity".

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE RULES LANG SUED UNDER ACTUALLY SAY

OrigamiUSA's published guidance, the ground Lang's case was fought on, is worth knowing before anyone films a tutorial. Traditional models are public domain, so with a paper crane "you can do pretty much anything you like with it". Everything else needs the composer's permission to sell, even as a folded object. Teaching informally is generally fair use — but teaching at a convention requires permission "because a convention is a commercial activity", and a video made from someone else's diagrams "would still be considered a 'derivative work'".[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT ORIGAMI COSTS BEFORE LANG'S LAWYERS ARRIVE

The money pit in origami is not the lawsuit; it is the paper you fold badly. A grail sheet is €19.99 and single-use: fold it wrong and it is gone, which is why the advice is to buy the sampler and the €7.99 tissue-foil pack first. Origamido's commissioning route makes it plainest — a $500 workshop plus about $50 in materials, one full day on site, up to three artists sharing a batch. That is a course, not a purchase. And there is no Singapore scene to join: the one listed local group was last updated in May 2021 and its site now serves a sign-in page.[3]

NEXT DESCENTS · VOTE FOR TOMORROW'S HOBBY

Rug tufting — one machine at four hundred dollars, a yarn economy, and a finishing step nobody warns you about.

Shodō (Japanese calligraphy) — a brush, an inkstone and a rank ladder, with a tool spend that runs to six figures.

Gliding & soaring — engineless cross-country flight, a real licence ladder, and a second-hand market nobody outside it has seen.

SOURCES 1 Lang's own account of the case, read at source: the six plaintiffs, the federal filing, the 24 named works, the two title substitutions, the 2009 first contact, the move from California to New York, the settlement update of 21 March 2013 and every quotation. **The page names only Lang; the other five plaintiffs are not identified there.** 2 David Lister, "Copyright in Crease Patterns", The Lister List, 22 March 2002, read at source, including his statutory citation; OrigamiUSA's own copyright page and copyright FAQ, both read at source, for the derivative-work position, the convention rule and the traditional-crane line, quoted verbatim. 3 The specialist shop's own pages for the sheet and pack prices (p16); Origamido Studio's own page, read at source, for the $500 session and its structure. 4 OrigamiUSA's international group directory and its Singapore entry, read at source, with the creation and last-updated dates as displayed; the group's own linked site now serves a sign-in page. **A Singapore paper chain, a cultural centre and a library volunteer surfaced as leads only and are not named as current sources.**

FITNESS · BLOOD-FLOW RESTRICTION TRAINING

A 27-trial review in Biological Research for Nursing finds cuff training raises blood pressure

In adults over 60 the mean difference against no exercise was 5.30 mmHg systolic, interval 0.48 to 10.12. A BMC Geriatrics umbrella review is blunter still.

A systematic review of 27 randomised trials, published online on 28 October in *Biological Research for Nursing*, found that light training done with a restrictive cuff on the limb raised systolic blood pressure in adults over 60 by 5.30 mmHg against no exercise.[1]

The technique is simple and increasingly sold to older people: inflate a cuff near the top of the leg, lift something light, and the muscle responds as though the weight were heavy. The appeal is obvious for anyone whose knees will no longer take a loaded barbell. The claim attached — heavy-lifting results at light-lifting risk — is what this review tested, and only half of it held.[1]

What held: against doing nothing, the cuffs improved one-repetition maximum in knee extension, leg extension and leg press, and increased quadriceps cross-sectional area. Against conventional training the results were mixed. And the cardiovascular picture inverts the selling point — diastolic pressure 5.23 mmHg higher than conventional training, mean arterial pressure 5.81 higher.[1]

The authors' own conclusion is the honest one: apply the method cautiously and individually, because the evidence does not support assuming cardiovascular superiority or even equivalence. Funding and conflicts could not be captured — the publisher refused this desk, so the record was read through a public literature index. General guidance, not medical advice.[1]

THE ARGUMENT · WHAT RESEARCHERS SAY ABOUT THE NURSING REVIEW

This box is researchers rather than podcasters, and deliberately: the *Biological Research for Nursing* paper landed into silence — two searches aimed at the longevity commentators and the training forums returned nothing attributable, and this desk will not invent a quotation. The promoters' position, from a scoping review, is that the method is "a highly effective, low-risk alternative to traditional strength training methods" — while the same paper calls for standardised protocols.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE NURSING REVIEW HAS NOT ESTABLISHED

An umbrella review of nine systematic reviews, published in *BMC Geriatrics* on 27 August, is blunter than the *Biological Research for Nursing* paper. Its own words: "Clinical safety, falls prevention and patient-centred benefits are not established." On strength the cuffs beat light training — 0.44, interval 0.28 to 0.60 — but *lose* to heavy training, at −0.23, interval −0.41 to −0.05. Adverse events were "predominantly passively reported", the clotting data rest on 93 and 39 participants and "cannot establish clinical safety", and direct evidence on falls was absent. It was pre-registered and unfunded.[3]

ALSO ON THE DESK

0 of 9

REVIEWS REPORTING THE LIMB POSITION USED WHEN OCCLUSION PRESSURE WAS MEASURED — WHICH IS WHAT THE DOSE IS A PERCENTAGE OF[3]

SOURCES 1 Norouzi, Nobari, Jamali Masoomi, Saberisani, Niyazi and Mohammad Rahimi, "Acute and Chronic Cardiovascular and Neuromuscular Effects of Blood Flow Restriction Resistance Training in Older Adults", *Biological Research for Nursing*, published online 28 October 2026, doi 10.1177/10998004261502747, read at source through a public literature index: the 27 trials, the population, both comparison arms, every mean difference and interval, and the conclusion. **The publisher's own article page returned HTTP 403, so funding and competing interests are not captured and are not printed.** 2 A scoping review in *Journal of Clinical Medicine*, quoted from its published abstract and **not read at source; the publisher refused this desk.** 3 Chen, Yu, Wang, Yan and Liang, "Efficacy and safety of blood flow restriction exercise training in adults aged 60 years and older: an umbrella review", *BMC Geriatrics*, published 27 August 2026, read at source in full: the nine reviews, the overlap statistic, both standardised differences and intervals, the certainty gradings, the adverse-event wording, the sample sizes behind the clotting data, the absent falls evidence, the pre-registration and the funding statement. 4 Murdoch University's own release of 17 December 2025, read at source, for the design, the sample, the pressures and both quotations. **General guidance, not medical advice.**

DEPARTURES · JAPAN'S TAX-FREE REFUND

Shops in Japan no longer sell tax-free; the refund now happens at the airport

In force across Japan since 1 November: pay the full price at the till, carry the goods unchecked to a customs terminal, and complete it within 90 days of purchase.

Since 1 November, a shop in Japan charges a visitor the full tax-inclusive price, and the consumption tax is refunded only after customs confirms at departure that the goods are leaving the country. Purchases made to 31 October ran under the old rules.[1]

This is a change of mechanism, not of rate, and for anyone who buys cameras, watches or audio in Tokyo it changes the shape of a departure day. The threshold is 5,000 yen excluding tax, per day, per shop — and where a shop uses a procedure counter, same-day purchases across several shops combine there to reach it. The sealed-packaging rule for consumables is abolished.[1]

Then the trap. Confirmation happens at a terminal in the departure lobby, *before* baggage check-in, and every item must be with you. Checked bags cannot be retrieved for it. Confirmation is per receipt: if one item from a receipt is missing, nothing on that receipt qualifies — including what you are still holding. A green result completes it; a red one sends you to inspection.[1]

Visit Japan Web lets the paperwork be pre-completed online at Narita, Haneda, Kansai, Chubu, Fukuoka, New Chitose and Naha. On a domestic connection the confirmation happens at the final departure airport. The practical reading: a Leica body bought in Ginza must now be hand-carried through the terminal, receipt intact, and queued for, before the bag goes on the belt.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE TRADE SAYS ABOUT JAPAN'S REFUND SWITCH

This desk will not manufacture a forum quote: the enthusiast boards and Reddit all refused automated reads, and nothing is attributed to them. What can be read is the operators' own copy, and it is blunt. Narita now carries a dedicated refund page; the ministry's guidance spends more words on what disqualifies a receipt than on what qualifies it. The departure tax is unchanged at 1,000 yen — the reported move to 3,000 sits in next year's tax discussions, so no figure is printed.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHO LOSES UNDER JAPAN'S NEW REFUND RULE

The scheme is now a test of logistics rather than of eligibility. Under the old system the discount happened at the counter and the traveller bore no risk. Under this one the traveller fronts the tax, carries the goods, finds the terminal, queues before check-in and absorbs the loss if a single line item is unaccounted for. The people who lose are those on tight connections, those with heavy purchases, and those who shopped on the last morning. **What would settle it:** published terminal waiting times, which nobody publishes.[1]

ALSO DEPARTING

Changi is now growing on freight, not fliers. Its own third-quarter figures, released 19 October: 17.4 million passengers, up 0.4 per cent; 574,000 tonnes of airfreight, up 8.0 per cent, driven by semiconductor and electronics shipments. Four new passenger airlines joined in the quarter — Oman Air to Muscat, Sun PhuQuoc daily, AirBorneo to Kuching, 9 Air to Yinchuan. Among the top ten markets Vietnam grew fastest, at 20.5 per cent.[3]

Strike Jetstar Asia from the template. The airline ceased operations on 31 July 2025, sixteen intra-Asia routes with it. Anyone planning from an old file — including this desk's own standing brief, now corrected — will route a reader onto a carrier that no longer exists.[4]

¥5,000

THE NEW DAILY SINGLE-SHOP MINIMUM — COMBINABLE ACROSS SHOPS AT A PROCEDURE COUNTER, REFUNDED ONLY ON A GREEN RESULT[1]

SOURCES 1 The Japan Tourism Agency's own tax-free guidance page, read at source 7 November 2026, for the 1 November effect, the 5,000-yen threshold, the combination rule, the 90-day limit, the before-check-in requirement, the per-receipt rule and the green and red results; Narita Airport's own refund page as corroboration. 2 The same two pages for the operators' own wording. **Reddit, FlyerTalk and the miles blogs' comment threads all refused automated reads, so no community voice is quoted anywhere on this desk, and the departure-tax figure is held rather than printed.** 3 Changi Airport Group's own quarterly operating indicators, released 19 October 2026, read at source. 4 The airline's closure as reported by the aviation trade press; the parent group announced it on 11 June 2025 and operations ended 31 July 2025.

DEPARTURES · SINGAPORE AIRLINES' NEW CABINS

Singapore Airlines unveils new First and Business, then delays both to late 2027

A seat first promised for 2021 becomes a second-half-of-2027 product, across 41 retrofits and 31 new aircraft, at a cost of more than S$2bn.

Singapore Airlines showed its new First and Business cabins on Friday 6 November and said in the same briefing that they will be introduced only "progressively... from the second half of 2027". It would not name which aircraft carries them first.[1]

The products are serious. First sits one-two-one behind 67-inch sliding doors, the centre pair converting to a double bed of eighty inches by sixty; Business takes 52-inch doors. PriestmanGoode designed First with Collins Aerospace building the seat and Poltrona Frau the leather; Business came from Designworks, a BMW company, with RECARO building. The bill across four cabins is more than two billion Singapore dollars.[1]

The delay is the story, and this is the fourth published timeline for the same seat. Announced in 2018 for a 2021 debut on the 777-9; moved in November 2024 to the A350s; slipped in May 2026; now late 2027, on an aircraft type to be confirmed. Both seats are certified on the 777-9; neither on the A350; and the 777-9 is not certified at all.[1]

Elsewhere it is moving metal rather than seats. Auckland becomes a year-round A380 — 471 seats a flight against 264 — and Christchurch takes a four-class 777-300ER from 1 May 2027, returning First Class to the South Island for the first time since 2002. Melbourne loses its A380 on 28 March. Dubai has been abandoned a seventh time, now to 1 March 2027: a full year with no service.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE TRADE PRESS MADE OF THE CABIN DELAY

Honest sourcing note first: the airline's own newsroom serves a firewall denial to this desk, so everything above is the trade's reporting of its briefing rather than its own text, and the enthusiast forums refused automated reads. Mainly Miles counted this as the fourth timeline for one product and noted the airline will no longer commit to a launch aircraft. Even the reveal date was reported inconsistently across three outlets.[1]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE 2027 CABIN DATE MAY ALSO SLIP

Every previous date for this seat was also announced with confidence. The airline attributes the slip to "several factors, rather than one issue alone" — aircraft delays, certification, manufacturing, supply chain — none of which it controls, and the one aircraft on which both seats are certified is itself uncertified. No launch routes have been named. **What would settle it:** an A350 certification for either seat, or a named first route. Until then the useful planning assumption is 2028.[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

The American Express KrisFlyer cards got better on 1 November, and the Ascend lost its hotel night. Earn rates rise to 1.3 miles a dollar on the Blue and 1.5 on the Ascend, with the two Priority-Passenger cards flattened to 1.5. The renewal voucher goes from 10,000 to 15,000 miles. But the free Hilton night and the Honors Silver status are discontinued, and an unused voucher must be *stayed* by 31 December — so booked by about 16 December.[3]

Changi's oneworld lounges reshuffled from 25 October. Qatar Airways' Premium Lounge in Terminal 1 is back to daily mornings, 07:15 to 10:15, evenings 17:15 to 03:15 — First and Business only, status alone will not get you in. The Qantas Business Lounge cut mornings to three days a week, none at all on Wednesday or Saturday. The losers are oneworld cardholders in economy.[4]

+78%

SEATS A FLIGHT ON AUCKLAND ONCE THE A380 RUNS YEAR-ROUND — 471 AGAINST 264, WITH BUSINESS UP 63 PER CENT[2]

SOURCES 1 Mainly Miles, 6 November 2026, read at source, for the specifications, the designers, the cost, the quoted timing and the slip history. **The airline's own newsroom and product pages serve a firewall denial to this desk, so no figure on this page is read in the airline's own text and all of it is flagged as trade reporting of its briefing.** 2 The same outlet, 27 October and 31 October 2026, read at source, for the Auckland capacity change, the Christchurch aircraft swap, the Melbourne withdrawal and the seventh Dubai postponement with its revised schedule. 3 The same outlet, 4 November 2026, read at source, for the earn rates, the fees, the voucher change and the discontinued hotel benefits. 4 The same outlet, 26 and 27 October 2026, read at source, for both lounges' revised hours and their access rules.

THE GRAND TOUR · SIEM REAP & ANGKOR

Foreign visitors to Angkor fell 26 per cent to 566,714 in ten months

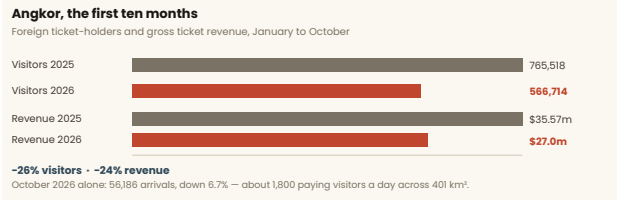
Ticket revenue fell 24 per cent to US$27m. The emptiest Angkor since the pandemic is the work of a border war, a scam-centre crackdown and the price of jet fuel.

Angkor Enterprise, the Cambodian state ticketing authority, reported on 2 November that 566,714 foreign visitors bought passes in the first ten months of 2026, down 26 per cent, on revenue of US$27m, down 24. October alone brought 56,186.[1]

Every piece of writing about Angkor for twenty years has been about crowds. That is not the place in November 2026: across 401 square kilometres and 91 temples, October's arrivals work out at about 1,800 paying foreign visitors a day. The tourism minister, Huot Hak, blames the regional scam-compound scandal, the border confrontation with Thailand, and fuel costs.[1]

The month is the other half of the argument. This desk built a thirty-year climate series for Siem Reap from reanalysis data, and November is the one month that gives both halves of the trip: a mean daily maximum of 30.2°C, the joint-coolest of the year, 78mm of rain across about ten wet days — and moats still full from the 508mm that fell in September and October. December and January are drier, at 17mm and 11mm, but the water has gone and the price has doubled.[2]

What to avoid is March to May: mean maxima of 34.1°C in both March and April, recorded highs of 38.5 and 39.8, April nights that never fall below 25.9. Angkor Wat's galleries are unshaded sandstone that holds heat, Bayon's upper terrace has none at all, and Khmer New Year puts a domestic crowd into the worst of it. April already carries 108mm across fifteen wet days.[2]



The 2025 comparison is from the same report series; the percentage changes are the authority's own.[1]

WHAT THE FORUMS ACTUALLY SAY · ABOUT ANGKOR'S SUNRISE

An honesty flag first: **every traveller forum refused automated reads this week** — Reddit entirely, TripAdvisor, Travelfish and the expat boards all with 403s — so nothing here is a quotation and no handle is named. What the published guides and the climate data agree on is that the Angkor Wat sunrise is oversold. You arrive at five in the dark, join several hundred people three deep at the pools, and the reflection works only when the pools hold water, which in the dry season they often do not.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY AN EMPTY ANGKOR IS NOT SIMPLY GOOD NEWS

A quarter fewer visitors is a quarter less money for conservation. Ticket income funds the authority that maintains the park, and revenue is down about US$8m against last year. September showed the shape of the adjustment — arrivals flat, revenue up 3.1 per cent, meaning fewer people buying longer passes. And the reason the park is empty is a border conflict that has closed the land crossings and put three temples out of bounds. **What would settle it:** whether arrivals recover, or whether 2026 sets a new base.[1]

BEFORE YOU BOOK

The airport moved, and it is the biggest change to the trip. Siem Reap–Angkor International opened on 16 October 2023, 50km east of the city, replacing an airport fifteen minutes by tuk-tuk from the riverside. Aman's Amansara page gives the number: 60 minutes from the airport, ten from Angkor Wat. A sunrise on arrival day is impossible.[4]

SOURCES 1 Angkor Enterprise's own figures in official statements of 1 October and 2 November 2026, carried by the Chinese state news agency and corroborated in a second outlet, both read at source: the ten-month and nine-month totals, the revenue figures, October and September alone, the minister's attribution and the park's dimensions. **The authority's own statistics page loads its content in the browser and returns nothing to a fetcher, so these are one step from primary.** 2 A thirty-year monthly climate series for 13.39°N 103.82°E built by this desk from the European reanalysis archive, 1995 to 2024. **Reanalysis smooths extremes, so real April maxima run a degree or two above the figures above.** 3 **Every traveller forum refused this desk: Reddit at the tool level, TripAdvisor, Travelfish, Fodor's, FlyerTalk and the Cambodia expat board all with HTTP 403.** The sunrise consensus is therefore characterised from published guides and the climate series, and is attributed to neither a person nor a thread. 4 Aman's own Amansara page, read at source, for both transfer times; the airport's own English site, read at source, for the absent flight board and the unpriced shuttle; the opening date from the civil-aviation secretariat as reported in 2023. **No primary closure notice for the old airport could be found and no official transfer tariff exists.**

THE GRAND TOUR · THE ANGKOR PASS

A three-day Angkor pass costs US$62 and stays valid for seven days

The seven-day pass costs US$72 and runs for thirty, so temple days need not be consecutive. Koh Ker, Beng Mealea and Kbal Spean are separate tickets.

Angkor Enterprise's own ticket page prices a one-day pass at US$37, three days at US$62 and seven days at US$72, with gates open from 05:00 to 18:30. The three-day pass expires in seven days and the seven-day pass in thirty.[1]

That expiry rule is the most useful line on this page for anyone travelling with a child. Because the days need not run consecutively, the right shape of a family trip is two temple mornings, a day at the pool, and a third morning later in the week — at no extra cost. Note also what the pass does *not* cover: Koh Ker is US$15, Beng Mealea US$10 and Kbal Spean US$5, bought separately. Anyone budgeting on one ticket for everything has it wrong.[1]

The honest ranking inverts the usual one. The best single thing at Angkor is indoors: the Churning of the Sea of Milk, 49 metres of the eastern gallery's southern half, 92 asuras and 88 devas hauling a serpent. It is shaded, which makes it the right thing to do between eleven and two when everything else is punishing — and most visitors walk past it to climb. Then Bayon's 54 towers, Banteay Srei's pink sandstone in the last ninety minutes of light, and Preah Khan, where almost nobody goes.[2]

For a twelve-year-old the best temple is not on that list. Beng Mealea, 60km east and US$10, is unrestored, collapsed and climbable — a legitimate scramble rather than a queue for one photograph, and genuinely unsupervised. The Angkor National Museum belongs on day one, before the temples, because it is what makes the reliefs legible.[2]

THE TABLE · WHAT TO EAT AROUND ANGKOR, BEYOND AMOK

Cuisine Wat Damnak is open, in Wat Damnak village, at US$45 for the tasting menu and US$38 vegetarian plus service and tax, Monday to Saturday — and its own page sets a minimum guest age of twelve, exactly on the line. **Embassy**, on the corner of Street 5, is open daily under chef Kimsan Pol and a kitchen staffed by women; it publishes no price. The real eating is breakfast: *kuy teav* and *num banh chok*, both essentially gone by ten. Kampot pepper's protected status is real, confirmed in European law in 2021.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT ANGKOR'S OWN AUTHORITY WILL NOT CONFIRM

Several of the rules every guidebook prints could not be verified at source. The conservation authority's own site returns HTTP 403 to this desk, so the photograph taken at the ticket centre, its hours, the under-twelve free rule, the refund policy and the tripod position are unverified and none is printed as fact. The top tier of Angkor Wat is confirmed open daily except the afternoons of the 14th and 28th — but the age limit, the hundred-person cap and the thirty-minute sessions trace to 2010 reporting. **What would settle it:** a telephone call before you promise a child the climb.[4]

THE HONEST FLAGS

The British advice is against all but essential travel within 20km of the Thai land border — which closes the classic Bangkok–Poipet overland route, and names three border temples as closed: Preah Vihear, Ta Krabey and Ta Muen Thom. Siem Reap and the Angkor park are not in the zone and are not named. The same pages report assaults on lone women by men posing as motorbike-taxi drivers around Pub Street, counterfeit dollar bills given as change, and landmines in unmarked rural ground — including, explicitly, around temple complexes.[5]

US$28

A TONLÉ SAP BOAT FOR ONE TO FIVE PEOPLE — PRICED PER BOAT, NOT PER HEAD, WHATEVER THE TOUTS SAY[1]

SOURCES 1 Angkor Enterprise's own available-tickets pages, read at source 7 November 2026: all six park prices, the expiry periods, the gate hours and the per-boat Tonlé Sap tariff with its 16:30 light advice. 2 This desk's ranking, on the published descriptions and dimensions of each monument; the gallery relief's length and figure counts as conventionally recorded. 3 Cuisine Wat Damnak's own site, read at source, for the two menu prices, the service and tax, the opening hours and the minimum age; Embassy's own site, read at source, for the address, hours and chef — **it publishes no price, and the undated menus circulating elsewhere are stale and are not printed**; Commission Implementing Regulation (EU) 2021/2046 of 23 November 2021, read at source, for the pepper's protection. **News coverage dates that registration to 2016 and this desk could not reconcile the two, so the formulation above is deliberately narrow.** 4 The conservation authority's announcement of 12 June 2026 as carried by the state news agency, read at source, for the 14th and 28th closures — **and for the absence of any age limit, cap or session length in the current notice. The authority's own site returns HTTP 403.** 5 The British Foreign Office's own Cambodia advice and safety pages, read at source, updated 19 March 2026 and current at 6 November: the 20km zone, the three named closed temples, the Pub Street warning, the counterfeit notes and the landmine advice.

THE DIARY · THE FORMULA ONE DEADLINE

Singapore Grand Prix tickets go on general sale at 10am on Wednesday 11 November

Raffles Grandstand at S$1,268, the Paddock Club and the Sky Suite have already sold out. In Tokyo, four major exhibitions admit a twelve-year-old free.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

13–22 Nov — **Singapore Writers Festival 2026**
VICTORIA THEATRE, THE ARTS HOUSE, NATIONAL GALLERY · **FESTIVAL PASS S$30, YOUTH PASS S$15** — TEN DAYS, 100+ PROGRAMMES · STEPHEN WITT 13 NOV, AMITAV GHOSH 14 NOV[1]

11 Nov — ★ **Formula One 2027 · general ticket sale, 10am**
MARINA BAY STREET CIRCUIT · STAMFORD JUNIOR **S$438**, PIT JUNIOR **S$888**, SUPER PIT **S$2,608** · **NO 2027 RACE DATE PUBLISHED**; WHEELCHAIR PLATFORMS BY PHONE ONLY[2]

20–29 Nov — ★ **Kalaa Utsavam 2026 · 25th edition**
ESPLANADE · **FREE PROGRAMMES PLUS TICKETED FROM S$25** · 40 EVENTS; *PAATI'S SPICE KITCHEN* FROM S$40 · SACHIN–JIGAR DEBUT, **PRICE NOT PUBLISHED**[1]

3–6 Dec

9–13 Dec — ★ **The Nutcracker · Singapore Ballet**
ESPLANADE THEATRE · **S$55 / 75 / 95 / 110** PLUS FEE · LIVE ORCHESTRA · **AGES 4+, EVERY CHILD TICKETED** · 20% OFF FOUR · **NOT 26–29 DEC AT SANDS, AS ONE LISTING CLAIMS**[3]

26–27 Dec
ESPLANADE CONCERT HALL · **S$88 TO S$328** · 7+ · MASAAKI SUZUKI'S ENSEMBLE, TWO NIGHTS · THE SUNDAY 4PM IS THE ONE TO TAKE WITH A CHILD[1]

8–9 Jan
ESPLANADE CONCERT HALL, SINGAPORE SYMPHONY · **S$15 IN THE TOP GALLERY** — THE CHEAPEST SERIOUS CONCERT ON THIS PAGE · 7+[1]

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

28 Oct–8 Feb — ★ **Shojo Manga Infinity · Hagio, Yamagishi, Yamato**
THE NATIONAL ART CENTER, ROPPONGI, TOKYO · **¥2,000 ADVANCE / ¥2,200 AT THE DOOR; CHILDREN 15 AND UNDER FREE** · A NATIONAL RETROSPECTIVE OF THE THREE WOMEN WHO BUILT THE FORM[4]

14 Nov–28 Mar — ★ **Masterworks from the Musée d'Orsay**
TOKYO METROPOLITAN ART MUSEUM, UENO, CENTENARY SHOW · ~110 WORKS · **¥2,200 ADVANCE; 18 AND UNDER FREE** · **CLOSED 22 DEC–3 JAN**, WHICH IS EXACTLY WHEN SINGAPORE TRAVELS[5]

to 20 Dec
TOKYO NATIONAL MUSEUM, HONKAN · **¥1,300 ADVANCE; UNDER-18S FREE** · THREE ROTATING PHASES — **ONLY PHASE THREE, FROM 25 NOV, IS STILL AHEAD**[6]

to 11 Jan
MORI ARTS CENTER GALLERY, ROPPONGI HILLS, TOKYO · **¥2,200 ADULT / ¥900 PRIMARY AND MIDDLE SCHOOL** · THE **¥4,400** MERCHANDISE TICKET IS THE LIMITED ONE[6]

13 Nov–14 Feb
TOKYO CITY VIEW, ROPPONGI HILLS · **¥2,200 ONLINE / ¥2,400 ON SITE; CHILDREN 4 AND UP ¥1,000** · **ADVANCE RESERVATION REQUIRED** · THE DECK CLOSES 10–12 NOV[6]

to 28 Mar — **Mariko Mori · All That Shines**
MORI ART MUSEUM, ROPPONGI HILLS · **¥2,600 ONLINE WEEKDAY / ¥2,800 WEEKEND; JUNIOR HIGH AND UNDER FREE** · THE TOKYO CITY VIEW COMBINATION EXPIRES 14 FEB[7]

4 NOV — **Niseko United · lift tickets on sale**

PLANNING NOTES

One hard deadline, and it is Wednesday. Singapore Grand Prix tickets go on general sale at 10am on 11 November across sixteen products. Raffles Grandstand at S$1,268 is already sold out, as are the Paddock Club and the Sky Suite. The family entry point is Stamford junior at S$438. The page publishes no 2027 race date, so this desk prints none.[2]

In Tokyo a twelve-year-old is the cheapest person in the room. Four of the shows above admit her free — the manga retrospective to 15, the Orsay show to 18, Mariko Mori to junior high, Hiroshige to 18 — while advance booking saves ¥200 at two and ¥400 at the third on a weekend.[8]

Four things this desk will not print. A 2027 Australian Open price band, because the tournament publishes dates and nothing else and its ticketing host returned HTTP 403 twice; Niseko's lift prices; and Christmas Wonderland, Light to Night 2027 and the Fringe 2027, unreadable at source for a fifth issue running.[9]

SOURCES 1 Esplanade's own event and festival pages, read at source 7 November 2026: dates, times, venues and every price category above, including the Writers Festival's two passes and the Kalaa Utsavam programme list. 2 The Singapore Grand Prix's own tickets page, dated 5 October 2026, read at source: the 10am sale time, sixteen priced products inclusive of goods and services tax, the three sold-out products and the telephone-only wheelchair platforms. 3 Singapore Ballet's own production page and Esplanade's own listing, both read at source and in agreement on 9–13 December at Esplanade Theatre — which is why the circulating Sands Theatre dates are not printed. 4 The National Art Center's own exhibition and ticket pages, read at source. 5 Tokyo Metropolitan Art Museum's own English exhibition page, read at source: prices, concessions, hours and the full closure calendar. **It publishes advance prices but not the advance-sale window.** 6 Roppongi Hills' own art-view information page, read at source, for both Mori Arts Center Gallery and Tokyo City View, their price tables and the reservation requirement. 7 Mori Art Museum's own exhibition page, read at source, for the weekday and weekend grids. 8 The three museums' own ticket pages, as above. 9 The tournament's own site, read at source, for the dates; **its ticketing host returned HTTP 403 twice, and the three Singapore festivals' own sites still serve last year's editions.**

THE TABLE · NOVEMBER'S RECYCLED OPENINGS

Four of five Singapore openings lists are recycling venues already open

Daniel Food Diary's ten November cafés include eight reviewed in October, one relocation and one from 28 September. Four venues survive a date check.

This desk read five Singapore new-openings lists at source this week, and most of what they carry is not new. Of the twelve entries on Eatbook's November list, at least eight are venues The Table has already covered to exhaustion.[1]

The mechanism is worth naming, because it misleads anyone planning a weekend. One major guide date-stamps publication rather than opening: its 6 November lead is a counter that opened in May, its Joo Chiat café entry has been open since August. A parenting title's November list leads on a Dempsey restaurant that opened in July. And Daniel Food Diary fills a November list with eight October reviews, a re-location and a September visit.[1]

Two names return from No. 148, and the delta is that neither has been reviewed since. **HANDO**, which this column met at its 30 October soft launch, is a counter whose proposition is the handroll made one at a time, the rice built to order — red or white vinegar, your quantity, wasabi and ginger as you ask. The entry tai roll is S$8++, the uni bomb S$28++, a three-roll lunch set S$28++. Not halal-certified. Eight days on, the buzz is still uniformly warm and still entirely pre-review, which is the finding.[2]

The other return is the least likely to be a good dinner. **OVER**, at 54 Tras Street since 28 October, is Zermatt Neo's first restaurant; every dish comes in three sizes — Lesser, Standard, Challenge — with an eight-kilogram platter from S$239++ to be cleared within the hour. The verdict run is now possible: one full review reports leaving "with major food coma", which here is promise and complaint at once, and the page's own rating is 3.5 from eleven. Go with four and order a Standard, not a Challenge. Reservations go through a social handle this desk could not verify.[3]

THE BUZZ · WHAT IS ACTUALLY KNOWN ABOUT THESE FOUR OPENINGS

Warmhouse Nasi Lemak is the confident recommendation and the cheapest: Chinatown Complex #02-223, run by Kenneth and his Taiwanese wife Cindy, a former photographer and a make-up artist. The Taiwanese salt-and-pepper popcorn chicken nasi lemak is S$5.50, the plain set S$5. The one review is specific about both sides: the chicken substantial and crunchy, the sambal thick and dried-shrimp savoury — and the rice "not quite your usual strongly fragrant, lemak Nasi Lemak". The chicken is the draw; the rice is the compromise. Open 10.30 to 2, Tuesday to Saturday only — the constraint is the clock, not the crowd.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY NONE OF THESE FOUR CAN YET BE JUDGED

Every independent channel this column normally reads was shut this week. Burpple returned HTTP 403, one major review site 403, another served an empty body, Instagram 429, and Reddit is blocked outright — so there is no forum sentiment, no diner consensus and no counter-view for any of the four. What exists is one review apiece and, at HANDO, none: an opening report is not a verdict. **Menya Saku**, at Sim Lim Square #02-03, is the honest illustration — chef Mamoru Kanaya won the Ultimate Ramen Champion in 2013 and 2014, a title contested between brands inside one food hall, and the sole reviewer called his chicken broth "pleasant enough" while preferring the S$14 black-garlic tonkotsu. **What would settle it:** a filed review of any of the four.[5]

THE HONESTY LEDGER

What to order, and what to ignore. At HANDO take the S$28++ lunch set and reserve judgement on the S$78 seven-roll one. At Warmhouse order the popcorn-chicken version. At Menya Saku order the Ajitama Black Garlic Tonkotsu at S$14, not the chicken bowl where the criticism lands; closed Mondays. At OVER do not order the Challenge.

SOFT-LAUNCH · TOO NEW TO CALL · HAWKER · COUNTER DINING

SOURCES 1 Five Singapore openings round-ups read at source on 7 November 2026 and checked entry by entry against this magazine's own Table ledger and against each venue's reported opening date. 2 HANDO's own site, read at source, for the address, the hours, the booking policy and the service charge; Eatbook's opening report of the same week for every menu price, the group, the chef and the halal position. **The restaurant's own menu prices render as unfilled template placeholders on its site, so the prices above are the outlet's.** 3 The venue's reported address, hours, three-size format and challenge price; one full review for the verdict and the embedded rating of 3.5 from eleven. **Instagram returned HTTP 429, so the booking handle is unverified and is not printed.** 4 Daniel Food Diary, 6 November 2026, read at source, for the stall number, the operators, both prices and every element of the verdict including the criticism of the rice. 5 The same outlet, 6 November 2026, read at source, for the address, the hours, the two broths, the prices and the chef's record — including the reviewer's own asterisk that the competition was contested within one food hall. **Burpple, one review site and Instagram all refused this desk, and Reddit is blocked, so no forum or diner sentiment appears anywhere on this page.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · JAPAN'S PART-INSURED MEDICINE

From 1 March Japan surcharges 1,042 medicines, and one ministerial order widens the list

Seventy-seven ingredients, from hay-fever tablets to purified water, honey and white petrolatum. The whole measure raises ¥90bn for Tokyo — 0.18 per cent of national medical spending.

On 30 September Japan's health ministry gazetted a list of 1,042 medicines which, from 1 March 2027, carry a surcharge of one quarter of the drug's cost on top of the co-payment a patient already pays. The drugs stay inside the benefit; a quarter of each is taken out of it.[1]

Japan has run universal health insurance since 1961 and has never done this. Benefits have been cut before and drugs removed before. What is new is a category in which a medicine is simultaneously inside the benefit and partly outside it — a thing with a dial on it. The dial is called *ichibu hoken-gai ryōyō*, 一部保険外療養: "partially-outside-insurance treatment".[1]

The test for inclusion is not clinical. A drug qualifies if its active ingredient, route of administration and maximum daily dose are identical to something on a drugstore shelf — the trade calls them OTC*類似薬*, OTC-analogue drugs. The ministry's word for how the seventy-seven were chosen is *kikaiteki*, 機械的: mechanically. Loxoprofen, sold here as Loxonin, accounts for eighty of the 1,042 products alone; epinastine for fifty.[2]

Read the list and the mechanical selection shows. Numbered among the seventy-seven are purified water, used as a solvent; white petrolatum, the base an ointment is mixed into; honey, a flavouring; grape wine, a tonic; malt extract, an infant laxative; magnesium oxide, which is how a great many elderly Japanese manage their bowels; and heparinoid, the standard moisturiser for Japanese dry skin. A pharmacy will shortly charge extra for water.[2]

The politics are plainer than the policy. The enabling statute passed on 29 May 2026 as the price of the Takaichi government's coalition agreement with Nippon Ishin, whose demand was a cut in working-age premiums. The ministry's own estimate of what the surcharge returns to the median insured person is about ¥400 a year — thirty-three yen a month — against a total saving of ¥90 billion on national medical spending of ¥49.2 trillion. That is 0.18 per cent.[3]

Set that against what it costs the people who take the drugs. At a press conference in Tokyo in March, **Ikeda Ryōko**, for the New Japan Women's Association, costed her three hay-fever prescriptions at about ¥1,500 a month more, and ¥4,000 for her household — roughly ¥20,000 across a pollen season. Her line travelled: 「花粉症の薬は贅沢な薬ではありません。」 Hay-fever medicine is not a luxury drug.[4]

WHAT THE PATIENT GROUPS TOLD THE MINISTRY, IN THEIR OWN WORDS

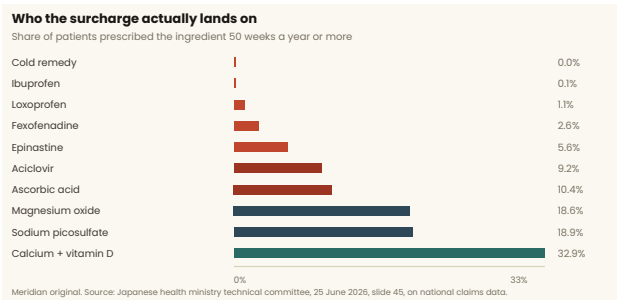
Submissions recorded verbatim in the ministry's own November 2025 design paper. The national federation of cancer-patient groups, whose members take maximum-dose paracetamol, loxoprofen tape and magnesium oxide: "some are agonising over whether continuing cancer treatment is even a good thing for society". The intractable-disease council: "a single day's hesitation over whether to see a doctor can decide life or death". And a medical rights centre noted the over-the-counter version can cost more than ten times the prescription one.[5]

SOURCES 1 The health ministry's own notice of 30 September 2026 read at source in full, with the ordinance of the same date: the 1 March 2027 start, the one-quarter charge, the definition by ingredient, route and maximum daily dose, and the three annexes. 2 The ministry's own first technical-committee paper of 25 June 2026, read at source and extracted as text: the seventy-seven ingredients, the "mechanically selected" wording, and the numbered list from which purified water, white petrolatum, honey, grape wine, ethanol, malt extract, magnesium oxide and heparinoid are taken; a pharmaceutical trade daily for the refinement to 1,042 products and the per-ingredient counts. **That trade daily's body text is members-only; the product counts are quoted from its public summary.** 3 The enabling amendment of 29 May 2026 and the coalition context; a Japanese legal-news outlet of 10 April 2026, read at source, for the ¥400-a-year and thirty-three-yen-a-month figures, and of 23 January 2026 for the ¥90bn estimate given at a doctors' federation press conference. **National medical spending of ¥49.2tn for the 2025 fiscal year is from a ministry release whose text layer would not decode and is carried from its published summary; the percentage is this desk's arithmetic. Note that ¥90bn is 900億円, not ¥900bn — one automated translation has made that error.** 4 The same outlet's report of the press conference of 12 March 2026, read at source, for the three prescriptions, all three costings and the quotation. 5 The ministry's own design paper of 27 November 2025, read at source and extracted as text, in which all four submissions are reproduced verbatim.

The reason this is worth a reader's attention in Singapore, three months before it starts, is not the seventy-seven ingredients. It is the sentence the two ministers signed on 24 December 2025, which commits the government to extending the charge to "a substantial portion" — *sōtōbubun*, 相当部分 — of all medicines that are not prescription-only, from the 2027 fiscal year onwards, and "also to consider raising the share of drug cost subject to the special charge".[1]

Then read the statute. The amended Health Insurance Act gives the scope of the exclusion to the Minister, by ordinance. Widening the list does not need a vote in the Diet. The article obliges the Minister only to "give consideration" to income, to the severity of the condition and to the content of the treatment. The ministry told the central medical-fee council in August that the list will be revisited at every drug-price revision — which, in Japan, is now an annual event. The ratchet has a clock on it.[1]

It is already turning. Between the December framework and the September gazette the list changed: a lipid drug, polyenylphosphatidylcholine, came off, and ramelteon, a sleep-onset drug, went on. The ingredient count stayed at seventy-seven, which is the sort of stability that looks like stability only in a headline. And the exemptions grew from six heads to eight — cancer patients under treatment, designated intractable diseases, patients on state medical schemes, drugs given in hospital or at discharge, drugs incident to tests or surgery, patients whose doctor certifies a year-round need, prescriptions for indications the over-the-counter twin is not approved for, and pregnant or nursing women.[2]



A hay-fever tablet is an acute purchase; a laxative or a calcium compound is a life. The median prescription of loxoprofen is seven days.[3]

The ministry's own data say the surcharge mostly lands lightly: about three-quarters of patients across the oral drugs on the list are prescribed them for under ten weeks a year, and only about one in twenty for fifty weeks or more. That is the defence, and it is a real one. But the average hides the whole argument, because the spread between ingredients runs from 0.0 per cent to 32.9. The drugs where almost nobody is a long-term patient are the colds and the painkillers. The drugs where a third of patients take them all year are the laxatives, the vitamins and the calcium compounds — which is to say, the old.[3]

The drug that was taken off the list between December and September is one of the two most chronic-skewed items on it.

And there is a detail in that table worth pausing on. Polyenylphosphatidylcholine — the drug quietly removed before the gazette — had 27.0 per cent of its patients in the fifty-weeks-or-more band, the second-highest figure in the ministry's own analysis. Whatever the reason for its removal, the item taken off was one of the two that would have hit chronic patients hardest. Ramelteon, which replaced it, is a sleeping drug.[3]

SOURCES 1 The finance and health ministers' agreement of 24 December 2025, reproduced verbatim as a slide in the ministry's own technical-committee paper of 25 June 2026, read at source, for both commitments; the amended Health Insurance Act article 63, quoted in full in the same paper, for the delegation to ministerial ordinance and the duty only to "give consideration"; the ministry's statement to the central medical-fee council on 26 August 2026 that the list will be reviewed at every drug-price revision. 2 The same paper and the kidney-patients' association newsletter of 13 July 2026, read at source and extracted as text, for the six original exemption heads; the gazette of 30 September 2026 for the two added. **That newsletter notes that even dialysis and transplant patients will not be outside the charge for every drug on the list.** The two list changes are from the pharmaceutical trade daily's public summary. 3 The ministry's own analysis of annual prescription-days from the national claims database, slide 45 of the 25 June 2026 paper, read at source and extracted as text: every figure in the chart, the roughly three-quarters and one-in-twenty shares, the 27.0 per cent for the removed lipid drug, and the seven-day median for loxoprofen.

There is a precedent, and it is European. On 1 January 2004 Germany did in one move what Japan is doing with a dial: the Health Modernisation Act removed non-prescription medicines wholesale from statutory insurance, keeping reimbursement only for children up to twelve and for adolescents with developmental disorders up to eighteen, and leaving a federal committee to maintain an exception list of drugs that remain standard therapy in named serious conditions.[1]

Two things about the German case matter. It worked fiscally: the 2004 saving came in at about €1.4bn against a legislated expectation of €1bn. And it was permanent — a parliamentary group moved to reverse it within ten months and failed, and twenty-two years later the exclusion stands while the exception list is fought over annually, item by item, in committee. That is where the German argument went: not to the principle, but to the annex.[1]

Germany's fight moved to the exception list. Japan's will move to annexes two and three, published on 30 September with almost nobody reading them.

Japan has chosen the softer architecture, and the softer one is the more usable. Keep the drug inside the benefit, take a quarter out, and you buy a gentler first year and a lever that moves without reopening the question of principle. Germany had to legislate an exclusion; Japan's minister need only raise a fraction. The German experience predicts where the Japanese fight will be fought: on annex two, which maps the disease names that escape the charge, and annex three, the drugs exempt for pregnant women and, differently, for nursing mothers.[2]

The case against calling this a turning point comes, awkwardly, from the opponents' own arithmetic. **Honnami Shōgo**, deputy secretariat director of the national federation of health insurance doctors' associations, calls the measure 「コスパの悪いあべこべな政策」 — a back-to-front policy with lousy value for money — because a few hundred yen a year of premium relief is swamped by one household's hay-fever bill. Taken seriously, that cuts both ways. At ¥90 billion against ¥49.2 trillion this is a rounding error dressed as structural reform, and a desk that calls it the end of Japanese universalism is over-reading a coalition bauble.[3]

There is precedent for the scepticism. When Japan capped medicated compresses at seventy sheets a prescription in 2016, and tightened it to sixty-three in 2022, a hospital study found no meaningful difference in total drug spending: the prescriptions reformed around the rule. And **Hamachi Masakazu** of Komeito told the lower house health committee on 15 April 2026 that generic substitution had already reached about 86 per cent through a decade of persuasion *before* the 2024 measure nudged it to 90.[3]

His sharper point was procedural. Generic promotion, he said, took "long years" of building public understanding before any charge was attached; this time 「今回いきなり法案化をされますね」 — it has suddenly been turned into a bill. The bureau's director-general replied that the scheme "is not a matter of telling people to just go to a drugstore when they catch a cold". An opposition survey of 8,098 valid responses found 94.7 per cent opposed.[4]

What this predicts is not a collapse but a sorting: Japanese illness divided into the insurable and the self-managed, with the boundary drawn, in the ministry's own word, mechanically — by whether an ingredient happens to have a drugstore twin. That is defensible for a cold tablet and indefensible for the magnesium oxide an eighty-year-old takes every day of the year, and the annexes exist because the ministry knows it. The number to watch is not ¥90 billion. It is the fraction, one quarter today, and the date of the next drug-price revision.[2]

SOURCES 1 Germany's Health Modernisation Act of 1 January 2004 and the resulting exclusion under the fifth book of the social code, with the children's and adolescents' carve-outs, the federal committee's exception list, the €1.4bn 2004 outturn against a €1bn expectation and the October 2004 reversal attempt. **The consolidated statute returned HTTP 503 to this desk, so all of it is carried from an insurance lexicon, a sickness fund's own explainer, parliamentary printed papers and 2004 conference abstracts, and is flagged as secondary.** 2 The Japanese annexes as described in the ministry's notice of 30 September 2026, read at source: annex two mapping indications that escape the charge, annex three listing drugs exempt for pregnant women and separately for nursing mothers, with the ministry's own warning that the two categories differ; the statutory delegation and the annual review as at p26. 3 A Japanese legal-news outlet, 10 April 2026, read at source, for Honnami's phrase and the premium arithmetic; the compress-cap study reported through a consumer-finance outlet — **the underlying study was not read**; the lower-house health committee record of 15 April 2026, reproduced in the ministry's own technical paper and read at source, for the 86 and 90 per cent figures. 4 The same committee record for both quotations; the same legal-news outlet, 10 April 2026, for the survey of 8,098 valid responses at 94.7 per cent opposed, and its report of 12 March 2026 for the earlier wave of 938 and the petition count. 5 **No Japanese platform thread on the measure was read: the main curation site carries none at all — its search returns 「該当するまとめがありません。」 with a tag count of nought, read at source — and two other platforms render their results in the browser and returned nothing. Every voice in this essay is a named person at a named press event or in a parliamentary record, reported by an outlet, not this desk's reading of social-media sentiment. A widely-repeated petition figure of about 85,000 signatures could not be confirmed; the 60,000-plus confirmed in March is used instead.**

THE LAST WORD

The unpinned number

A Japanese ministry has decided that seventy-seven medicines are a quarter less insurable than they were, and chose them, in its own word, mechanically — by whether an ingredient has a twin on a drugstore shelf (p25). The list includes purified water. The fraction is twenty-five per cent today, and the only thing needed to move it is a ministerial order.

It is the shape of the whole book. Sixty-seven members of the Knesset recommended a prime minister and nineteen of them cannot be used, so the real figure is forty-eight (p3). A treaty binding three states to each other's defence passed 279 to 119 on a text nobody outside three governments has read (p4). The ten-year yield fell eight basis points while the rate that actually prices gold went up three — the whole move was inflation expectations, not growth (p14). And the biggest opening day in the history of Japanese live-action cinema was set on a public holiday that is also Godzilla Day (p11).

The smaller ones are the same joke told quietly. A hat grade with no standard, conceded by the company that sets it: "We are the mean" (p6). An entire literature on cuff training that never recorded which way the leg was pointing when the pressure was measured (p18). A screen rule worth fifty-six minutes a day that gives thirteen of them back every birthday (p12). A three-day temple pass that lasts seven (p22). And, on p2, forty-five of our own numbers, nine of them wrong. Ask what the number is counting. It is rarely the thing it is named after.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

MERIDIAN · No. 155 · 7 November 2026

A note on method. Read at source this edition: Japan's health ministry's own gazette notice, technical-committee papers and design paper, extracted as text; Angkor Enterprise's own ticket tariff and the Cambodian authority's own visitor statements; the United States Treasury's daily par and real yield curves (p14); the Bureau of Labor Statistics' October release and the Federal Reserve's own statement; Qualcomm's and Arm's own filings; the Singapore Police Force's own releases; the Ministry of Manpower's own holiday page; Phillips' own lot entry; two medical journals in full; and every event on p23 on its promoter's own page. **Reddit refused every desk that wanted it for a fourth consecutive issue, so no forum sentiment is attributed anywhere except on HardwareZone and the Fedora Lounge, which served us; Singapore Statutes Online, the conservation authority at Angkor, Singapore Airlines' own newsroom and every traveller forum all refused us, and each page says so where it matters.**